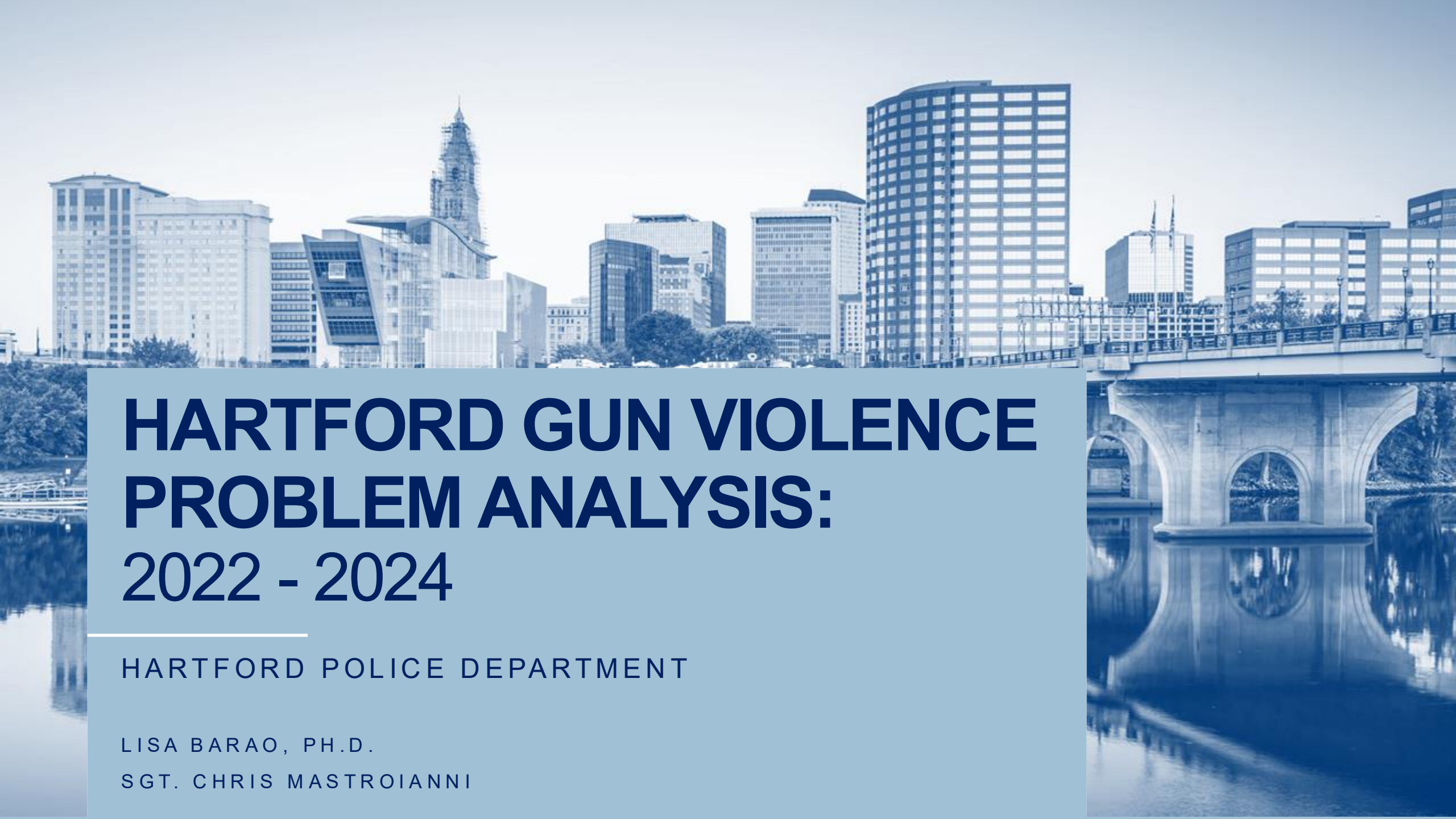

HARTFORD GUN VIOLENCE PROBLEM ANALYSIS: 2022 - 2024

HARTFORD POLICE DEPARTMENT

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INTRODUCTION

Introduction

- The Hartford Police Department partners with researchers to collect timely data on local gun violence dynamics. A report summarizing gun violence occurring 2019-2021 was published by the City in 2022. This report conducts an updated problem analysis of local gun violence for the years 2022-2024.

- A ”problem analysis” is a set of analysis exercises designed to support the implementation of violence reduction strategies. This methodology has been developed over the last 25 years and used in dozens of cities nationally.

- This analysis establishes a common understanding of the local violence problem that guides and informs the work of civic, community, and criminal justice leaders to reduce violence.

- The problem analysis identifies the networks and individuals within a community who are at greatest risk of violence and helps tailor an intervention to reduce that risk.

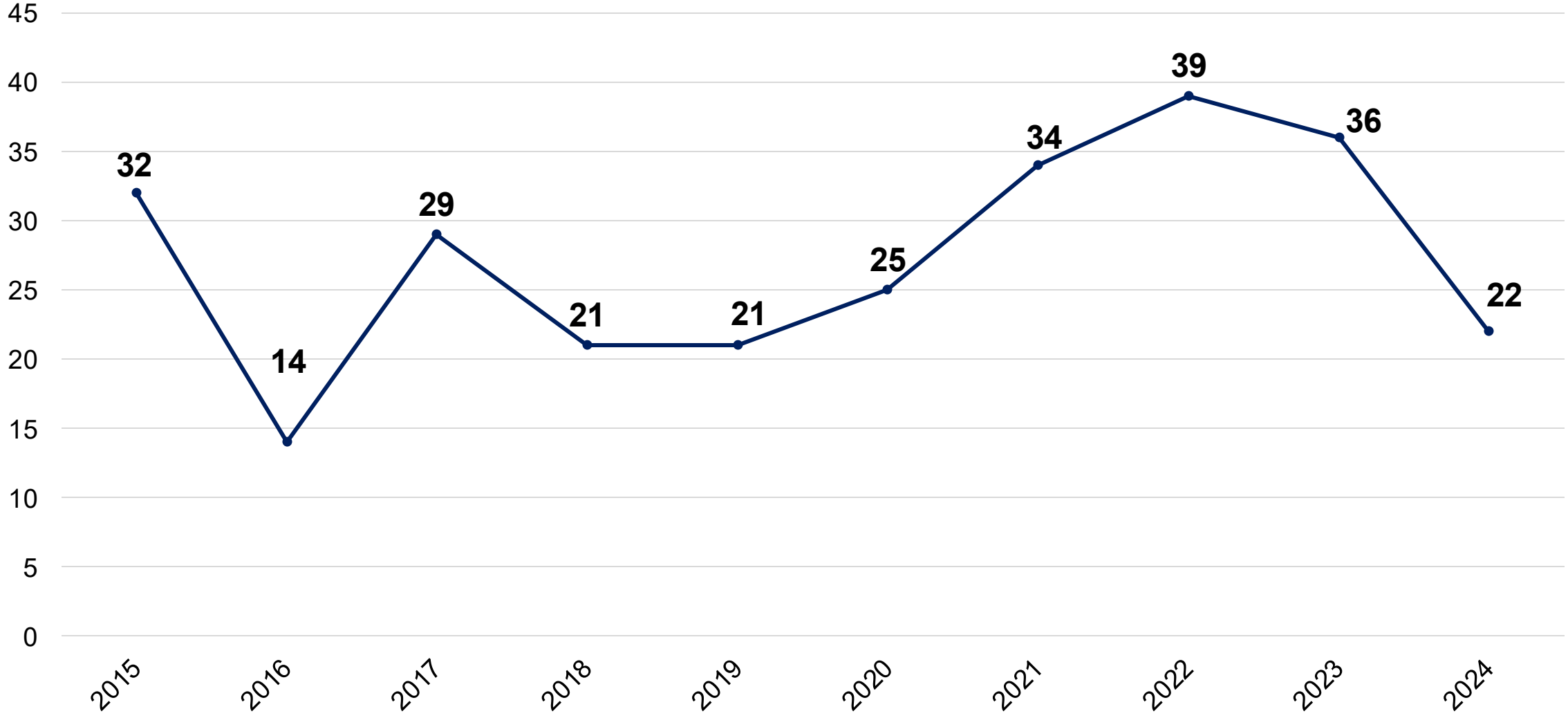
- Though the methodology is informed by research, the problem analysis is primarily a practice document with implications for local policy.

Introduction

- This analysis examines all homicides and nonfatal injury shooting incidents in the City of Hartford from January 2022 – December 2024 (excluding cases of justified self-defense, confirmed self-inflictions, and officer-involved shootings).
- This period included 69 homicides involving 129 unique victims or identified suspects and 262 nonfatal shootings involving 403 unique identified victims or suspects.
- Note that trend data counts homicides and nonfatal shootings at the individual level (i.e., number of victims) while the violence analysis counts homicides and nonfatal shootings at the incident level (i.e., number of events).
- This analysis examines the characteristics of these incidents and the involved individuals, including demographics and criminal justice system involvement. We also examine groups/gangs and social networks at high risk of involvement in violence, including their sizes and relationships, and the spatial concentration of violence throughout the city.

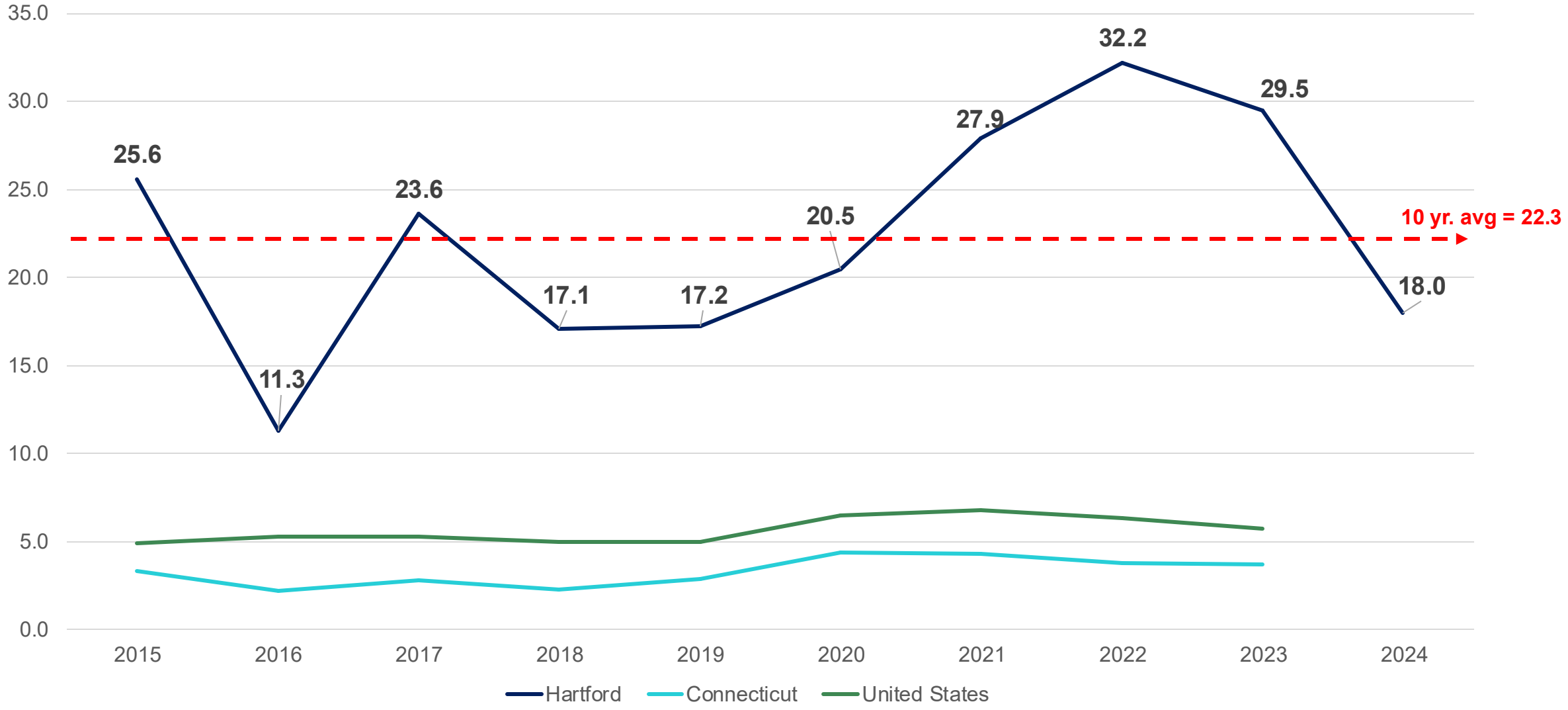
CONTEXT & TREND DATA

Hartford Homicides: 2015 - 2024



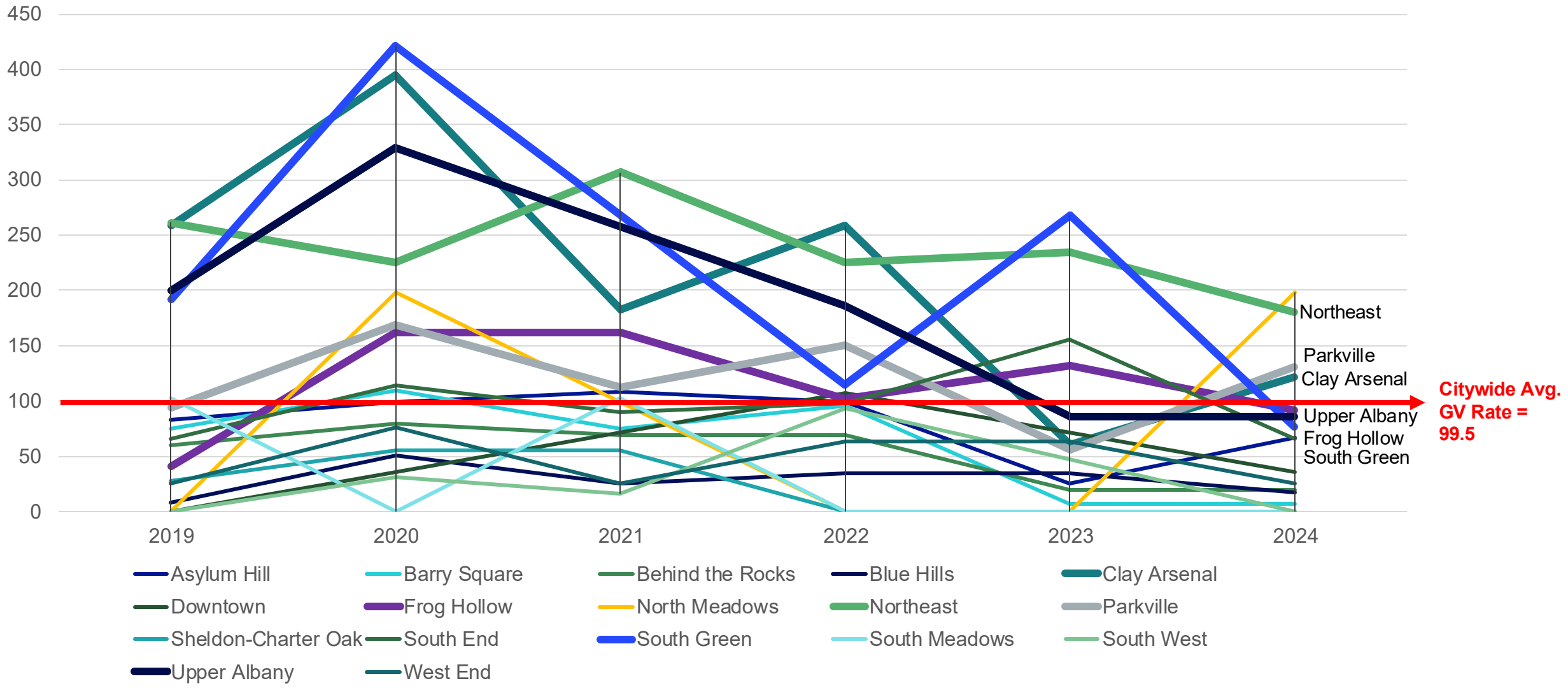
Source: Federal Bureau of Investigation, Uniform Crime Reports 2005-2021; HPD Internal Data 2022-2024

Hartford Homicide Rate (per 100,000 population): 2015 - 2024



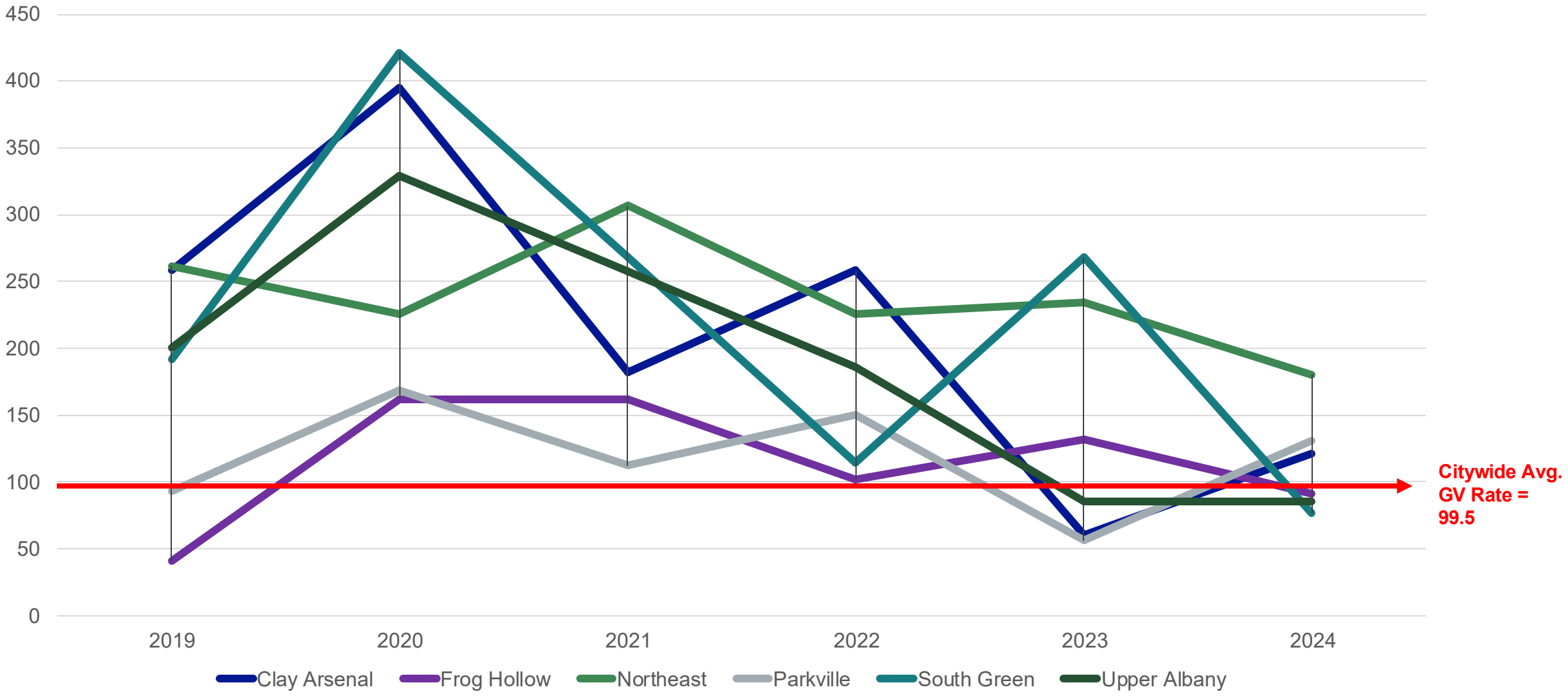
Source: Federal Bureau of Investigation, Uniform Crime Reports 2005-2023; HPD Internal Data 2022-2024

Hartford Gun Violence Rate (per 100,000 population): 2019 – 2024 by Neighborhood



Source: HPD Internal Data for 2019-2024

Hartford Gun Violence Rate (per 100,000 population): Top Neighborhoods 2019-2024



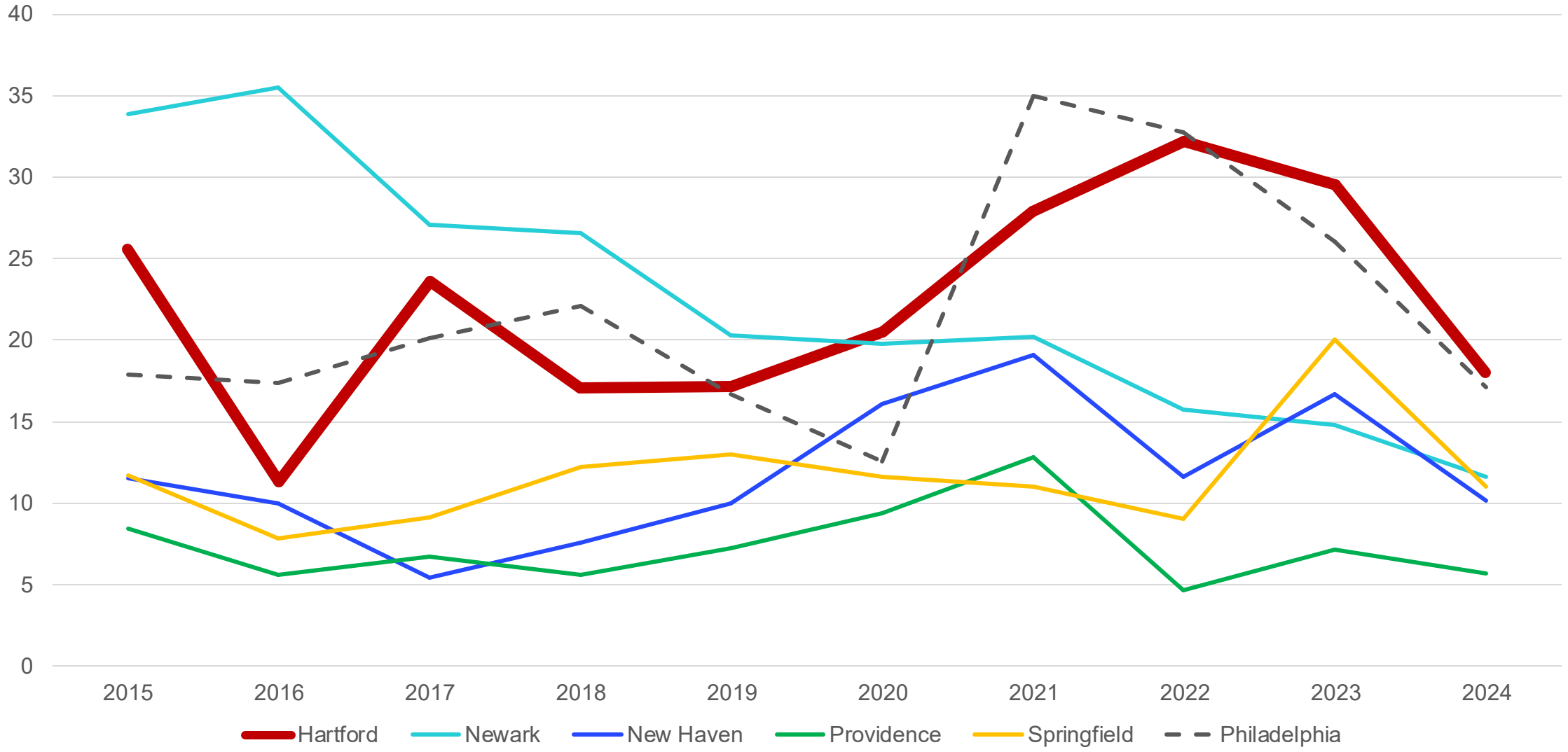
Source: HPD Internal Data for 2019-2024

Hartford Homicide Rate (per 100,000 population): Peer Comparison Cities

	2019 Homicide Rate (per 100,000 pop.)	Population	Population Density (per sq. mi)	Median Household Income	Unemployment Rate	Percent Below Poverty Line
Hartford, CT	**17.2**	**122,129**	**6,965**	**$36,278**	**11%**	**28%**
Newark, NJ	20.3	317,303	12,879	$35,199	10%	27%
New Haven, CT	10.0	137,562	7,174	$42,222	9%	27%
Providence, RI	7.2	194,706	10,376	$45,610	7%	26%
Springfield, MA	13.0	154,888	4,892	$39,432	5%	27%
Philadelphia, PA	16.7	1,573,916	11,960	$45,927	8%	24%

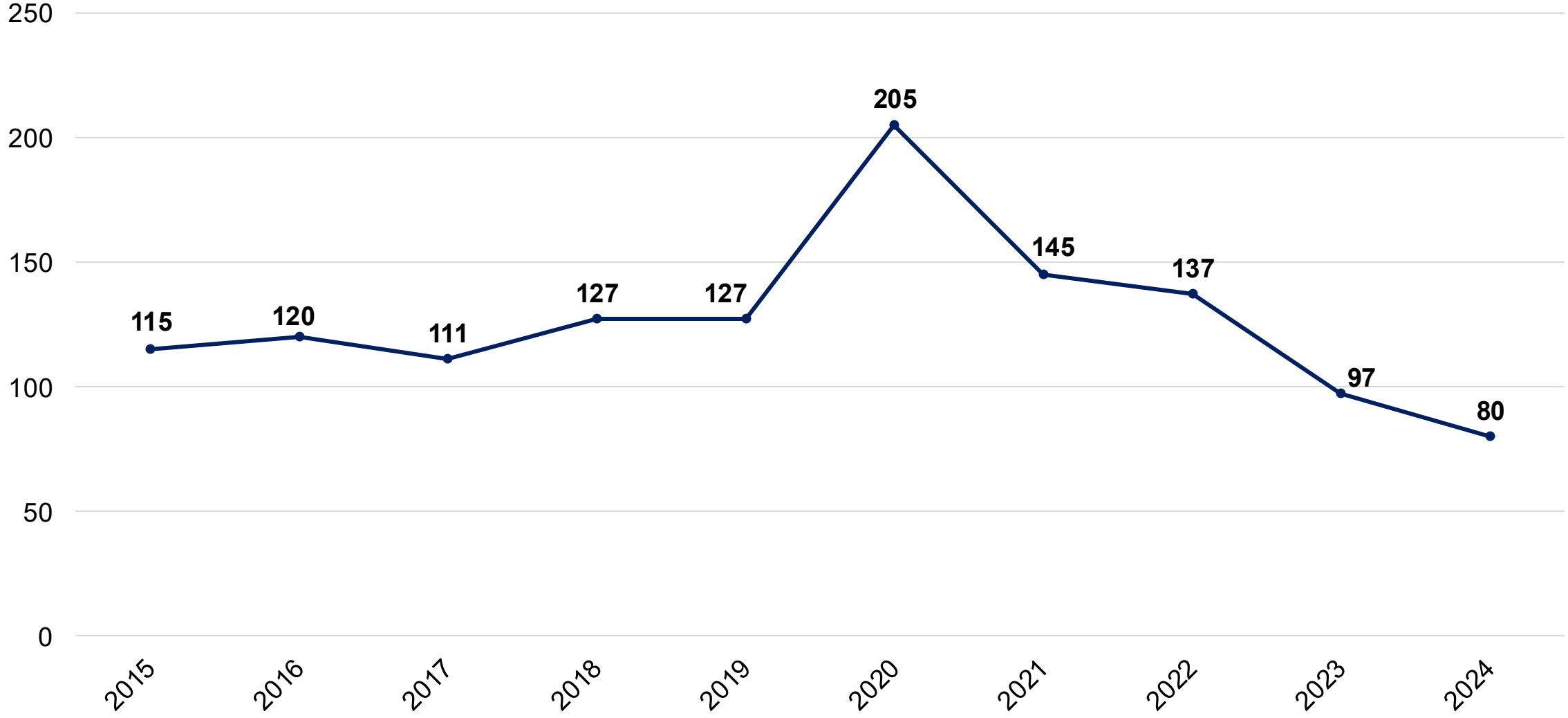
Source: Federal Bureau of Investigation, Uniform Crime Reports, 2019; Peer cities generated through use of the "Peer City Identification Tool," Federal Reserve Bank of Chicago using 2018-2022 ACS estimate indicators

Hartford Homicide Rate (per 100,000 population): 2015 – 2024 with Peer Comparison Cities



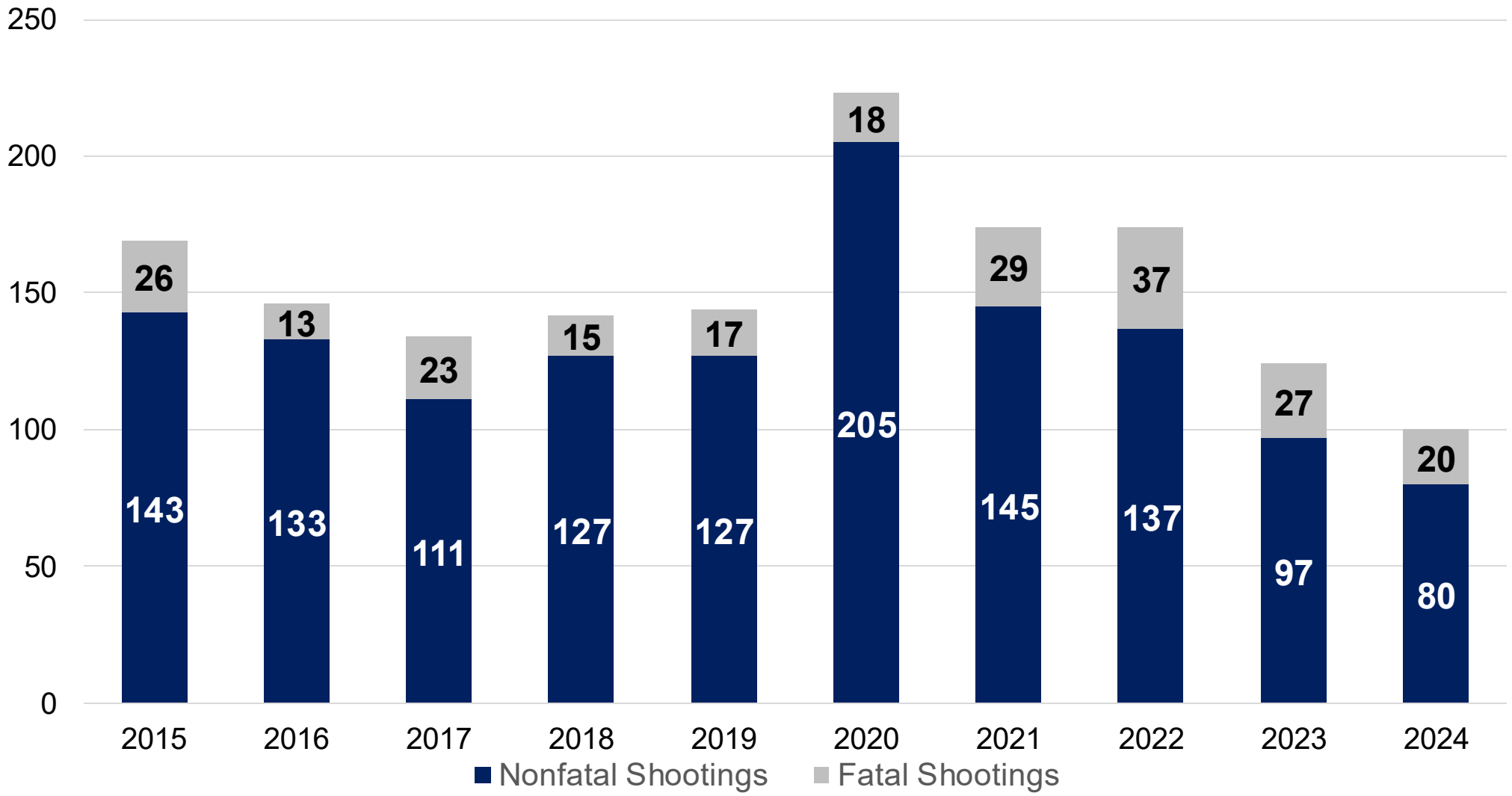
Source: Federal Bureau of Investigation, Uniform Crime Reports, 2015-2023; HPD Internal Data for 2024; Preliminary publicly available data sourced for peer cities in 2024

Hartford Nonfatal Shooting Victims: 2015 - 2024

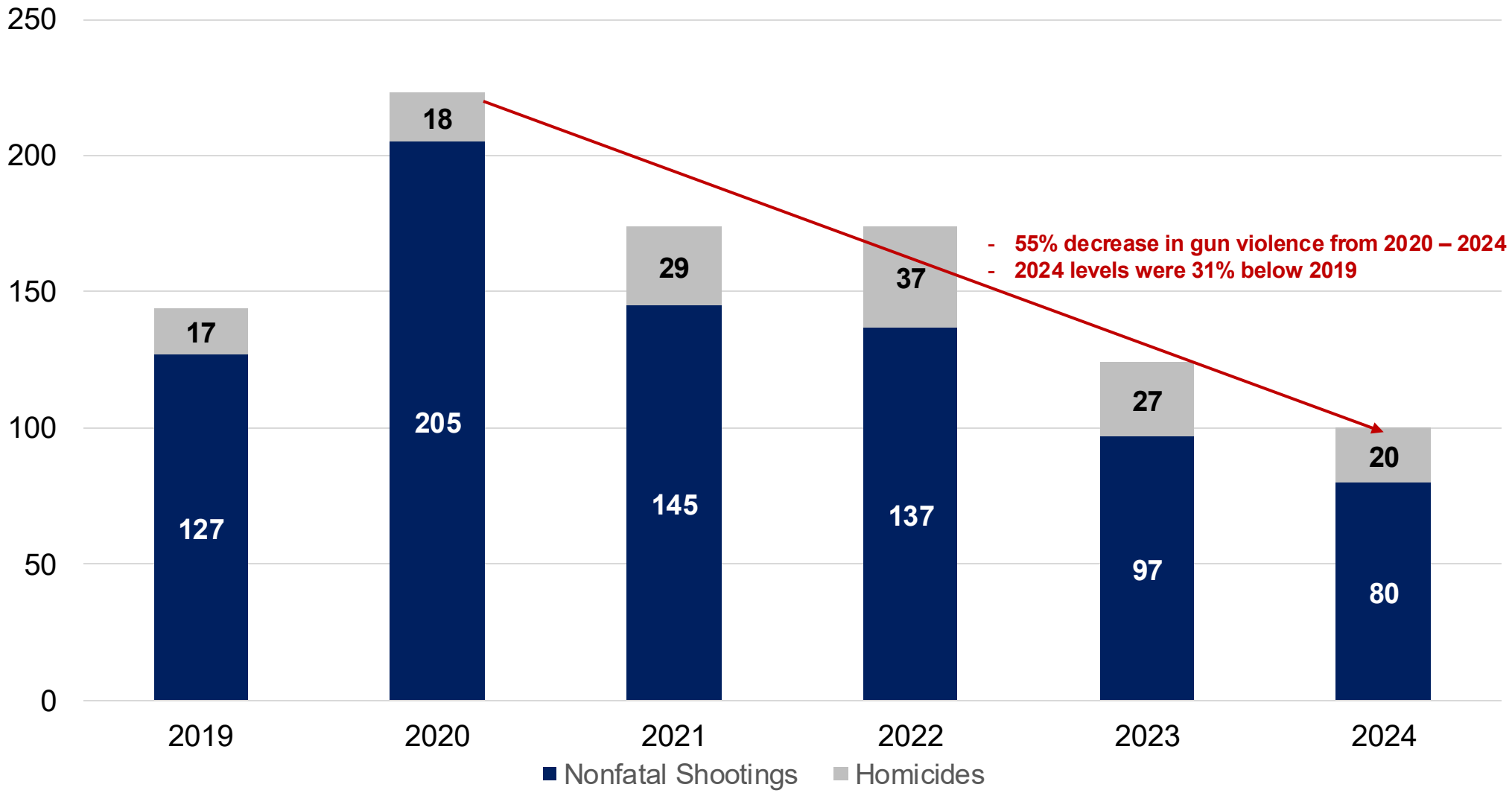


Source: HPD Internal Nonfatal Shooting Data

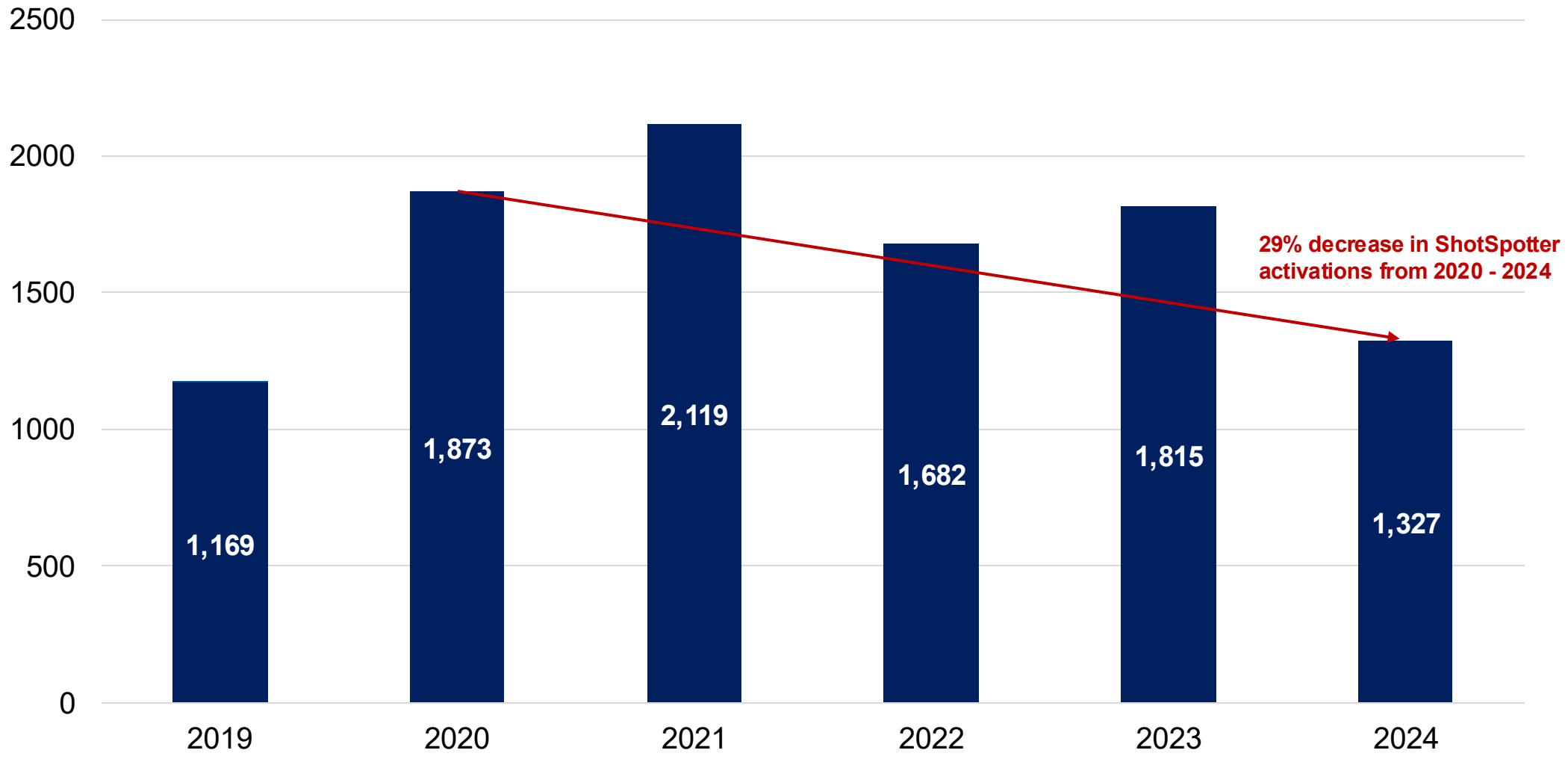
Hartford Fatal & Nonfatal Shootings: 2015 - 2024



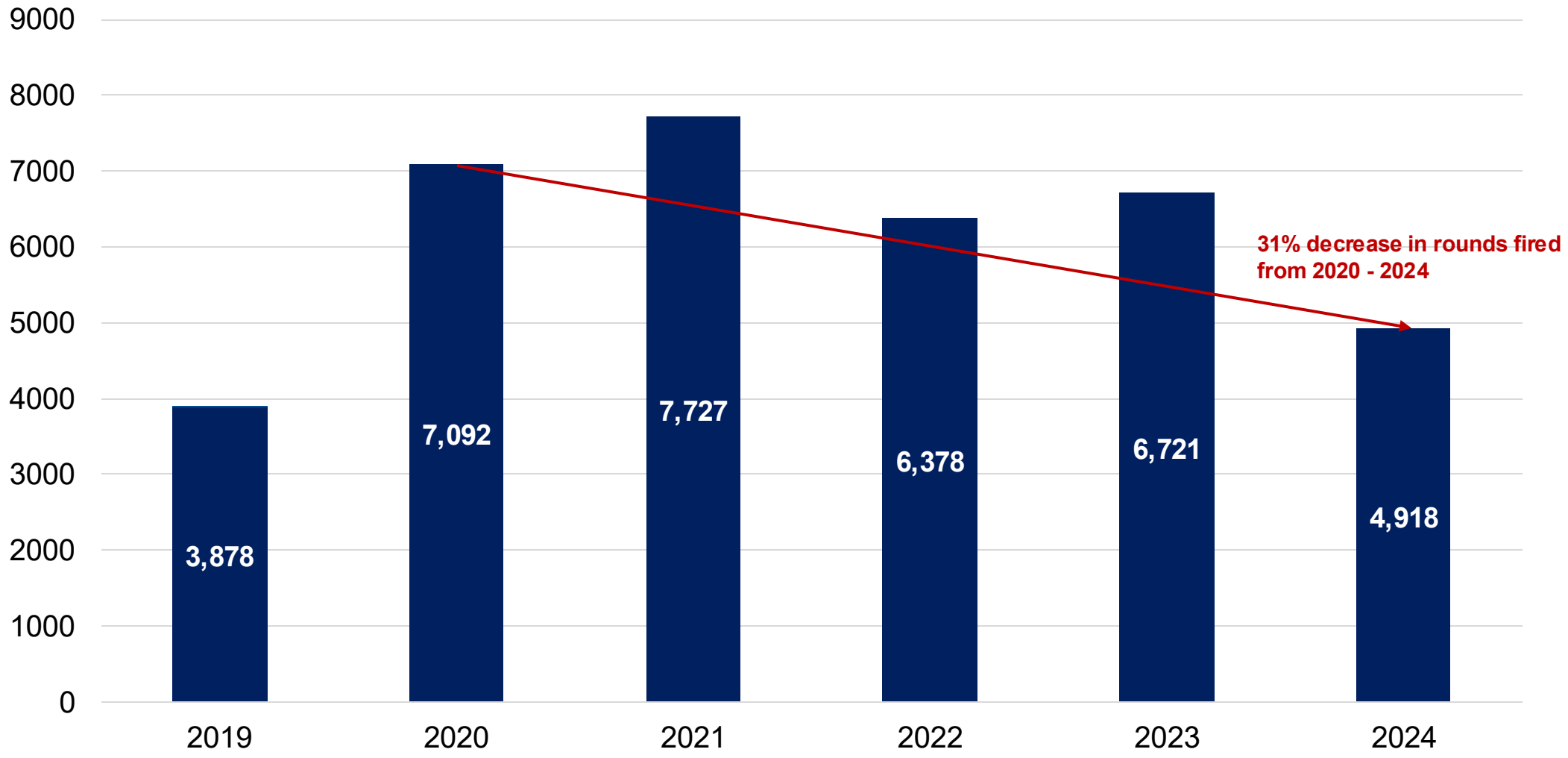
Hartford Fatal & Nonfatal Shootings: 2019 - 2024



Hartford ShotSpotter Activations: 2019 - 2024



Hartford ShotSpotter Rounds Fired: 2019 - 2024



Summary

- Hartford's average 10-year homicide rate is 22.3 per 100,000 population. The City's rate is routinely about five times higher than the statewide rate and about four times higher than the national rate.
- Gun violence disproportionately affects six key neighborhoods: Northeast, South Green, Clay Arsenal, Upper Albany, Frog Hollow, and Parkville.
- Similar to other U.S. cities, Hartford also experienced an elevated number of homicides and overall gun violence from 2020 - 2022.
  - Hartford experienced its highest number of fatal and nonfatal shootings in the past decade in 2020 (223).
  - Hartford's homicide rate increased by about 87% from 2019 (17.2) to its peak in 2022 (32.2).
  - However, the city experienced a correction to pre-pandemic levels of gun violence from 2023-2024.
    - Fatal and nonfatal shootings in 2024 (100) were about 55% lower than the city's highest level experienced in 2020 (223).
    - The homicide rate in 2024 (18.0) was 44% lower than the highest homicide rate experienced in 2022 (32.2).

VIOLENCE ANALYSIS

Introduction

- This gun violence analysis examines all gun violence incidents (fatal and nonfatal shootings) occurring between January 1, 2022 – December 31, 2024.
  - These 331 gun violence incidents include 69 gun homicides and 262 nonfatal shootings.
    - This analysis drops incidents that were deemed justified self-defense, accidental discharges, and self-inflictions.
    - In total, these incidents involved 148 unique suspects and 384 unique victims.
  - This section analyzes data on victim/suspect demographics, victim/suspect criminal history, and incident circumstances for fatal and nonfatal shootings.

VIOLENCE ANALYSIS

Victim and Suspect Characteristics

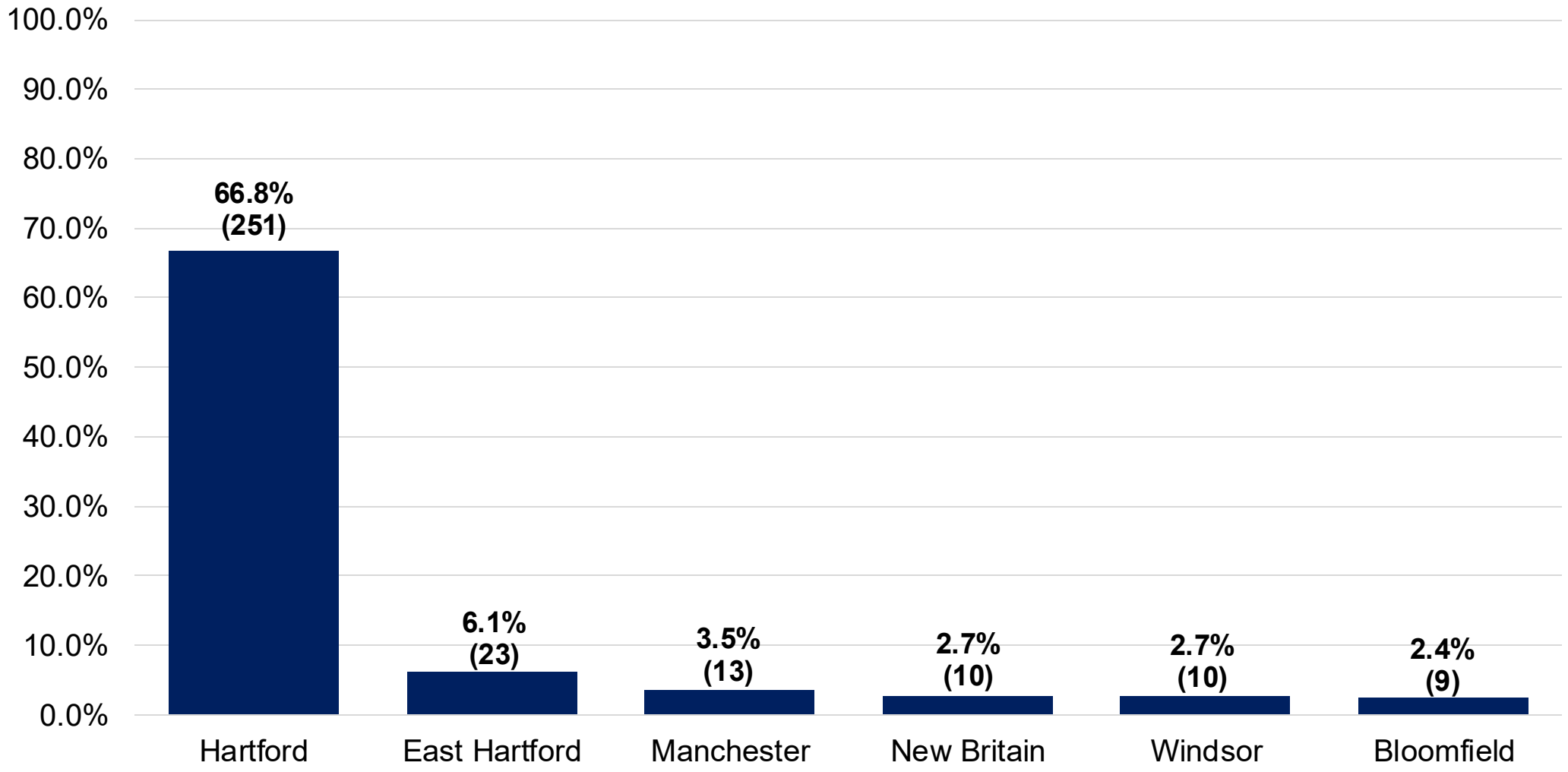
GV Victims & Suspects: Sex and Race

	FATAL & NONFATAL SHOOTINGS (N=331)			HARTFORD POPULATION
	Victims (n=384)	Suspects (n=148)	Victims & Suspects (n=532)	
Sex				
Male	**88.8%**	**97.2%**	**91.1%**	**47.6%**
Female	11.2%	2.8%	8.9%	**52.4%**
Race				
Black	**63.6%**	**73.3%**	**66.2%**	**44.3%**
Hispanic	34.6%	26.7%	32.5%	**37.7%**
White	1.3%	0.0%	1.0%	**14.8%**
Other	0.5%	0.0%	0.4%	**-**

GV Victims & Suspects: Age

	FATAL & NONFATAL SHOOTINGS (N=331)		
	Victims (n=384)	Suspects (n=148)	Victims & Suspects (n=532)
Age			
17 & under	7.3%	6.3%	7.0%
18-24	**27.1%**	**24.7%**	**26.4%**
25-34	**31.5%**	**40.9%**	**34.0%**
35-44	22.4%	20.4%	21.9%
45-54	8.1%	5.6%	7.4%
55+	3.7%	2.1%	3.2%
Average Age	31.0	30.0	30.7

GV Victims: Town of Residence (Top Five)



VIOLENCE ANALYSIS

Victim and Suspect Criminal History

GV Victims & Suspects:
CJ System Contact

	FATAL & NONFATAL SHOOTINGS (N=331)		
	Victims (n=384)	Suspects (n=148)	Victims & Suspects (n=532)
Known to the CJ system prior to the incident	62.7%	69.8%	69.4%
Of those known to the CJ system:*			
Prior incarceration	**53.7%**	**56.3%**	**54.4%**
Convicted of felony	**55.6%**	**61.5%**	**57.1%**
Prior probation	**55.6%**	**50.0%**	**54.1%**
Active probation	11.9%	19.8%	14.0%
Active parole	0.8%	6.3%	2.2%
Average prior Hartford arrests	6.7	6.2	6.5
Average prior Hartford felony arrests	2.9	2.8	2.9

*Incarceration, felony convictions, and supervision collected from combined HPD data and CT Judicial data, which may not capture convictions before 2015. These measures should be considered conservative estimates.

GV Victims & Suspects:
Prior Hartford Offense Detail

	FATAL & NONFATAL SHOOTINGS (N=331)		
	Victims (n=384)	Suspects (n=148)	Victims & Suspects (n=532)
Of those with prior arrests:	62.7%	69.8%	69.4%
Serious violent offenses*	0.3	0.4	0.4
Lesser violent offenses	**1.1**	**1.2**	**1.1**
Firearm offenses	0.4	0.8	0.5
Drug offenses	**1.8**	**1.4**	**1.7**
Property offenses	**1.1**	**1.1**	**1.1**
Disorder offenses	**2.8**	**2.5**	**2.7**
Other offenses	0.4	0.5	0.4
Total	7.9	7.9	7.9

*Violent offenses in the 1st or 2nd degree

Summary – Victims & Suspects

- The victims and suspects involved in gun violence were predominantly Black (66%) and Hispanic (33%) males (91%) between the ages of 18-34 (60%).
- The greatest percentage of victims and suspects were between the ages of 25-34 (34%) and the average age was 31.
- When compared to the composition of Hartford's population overall, Black individuals were overrepresented among victims and suspects of gun violence by a factor of about 1.5.
- Most of Hartford's gun violence victims (67%) are Hartford residents. An additional 6% were East Hartford residents and 4% were Manchester residents.

Summary – Victims & Suspects

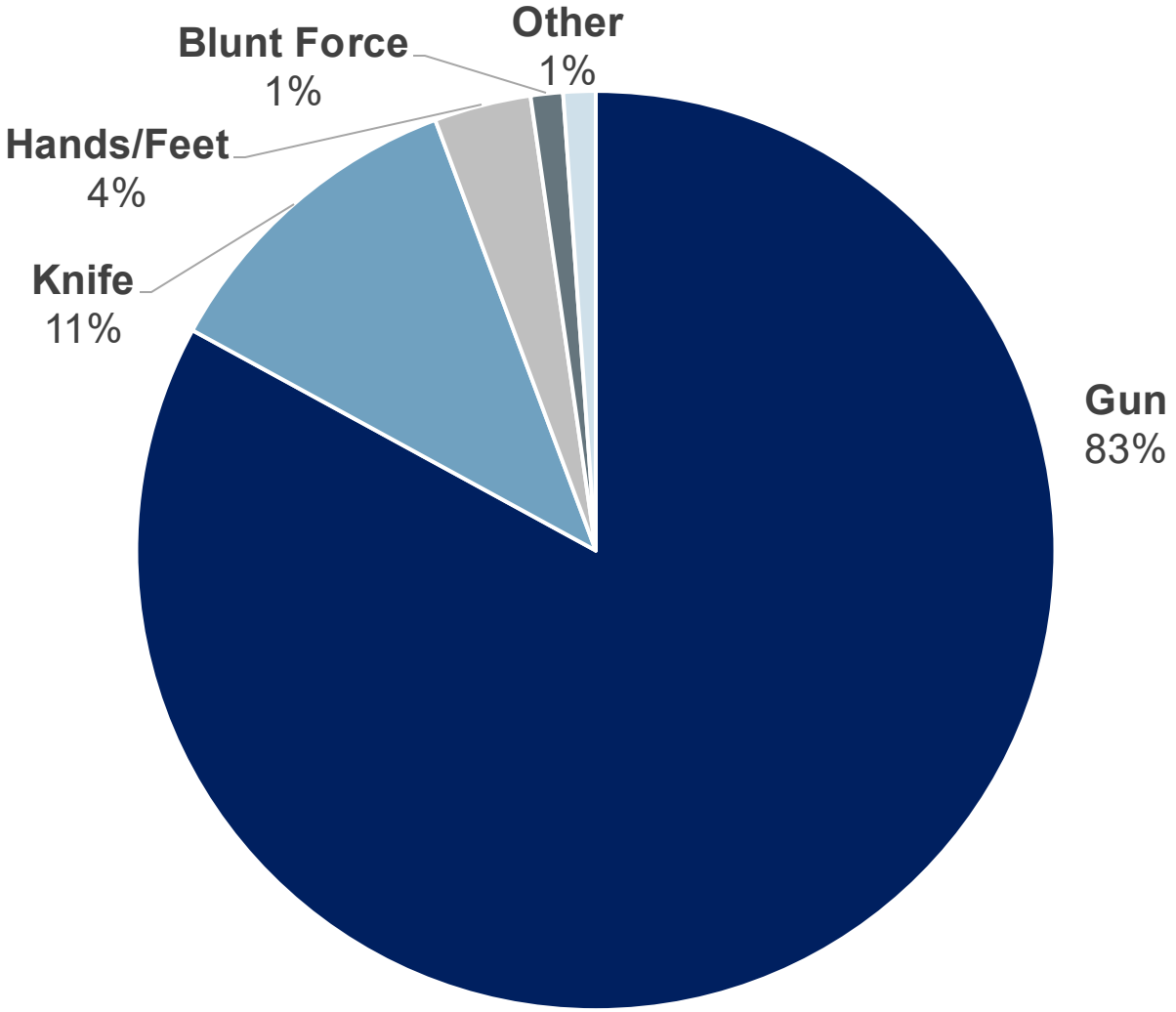
- According to Hartford criminal history data, at least 69% of victims and suspect had prior criminal justice system contact before their involvement in these incidents.

- Of those with prior arrests, most have extensive criminal involvement:
  - At least 54% had been previously incarcerated and 57% had been convicted of a felony.
  - At least 54% had prior probation and 14% were on active probation
  - Victims and suspects committed an average 8 prior criminal offenses in Hartford before their involvement in the gun violence incident– predominantly disorder, drug, property, and lesser degree violent offenses, respectively.

VIOLENCE ANALYSIS

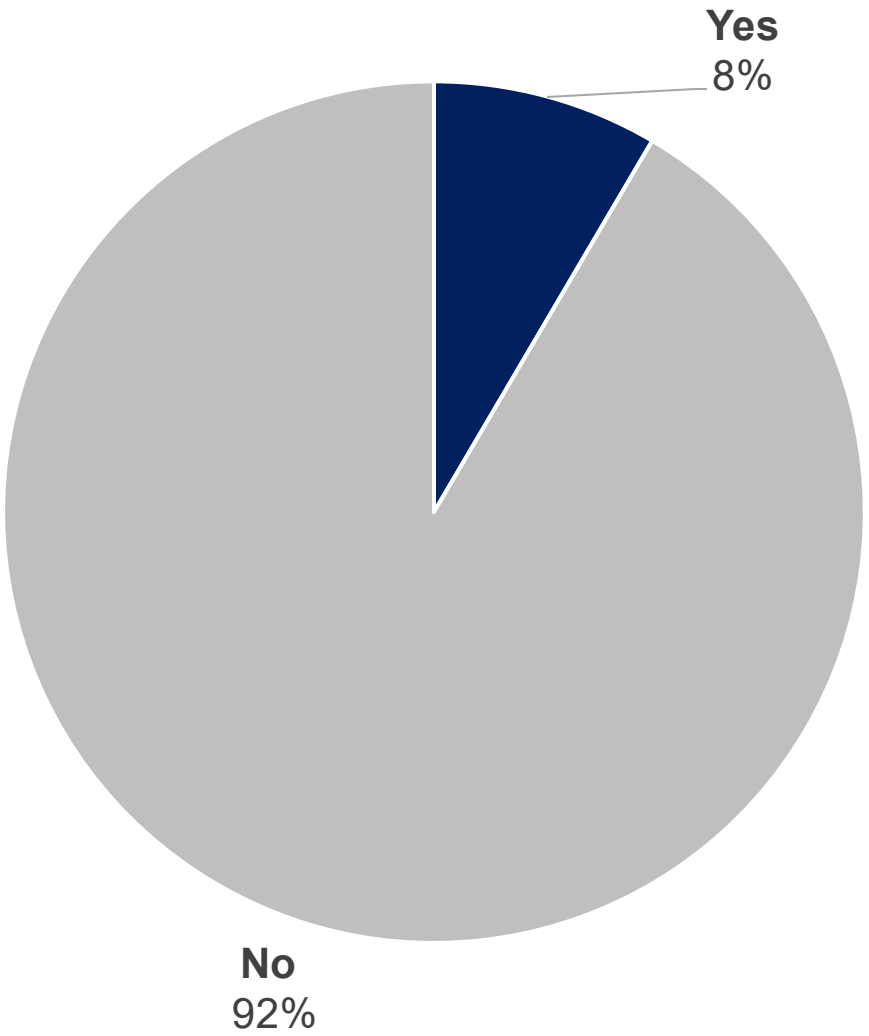
Incident Circumstances

All Homicides: Manner of Death



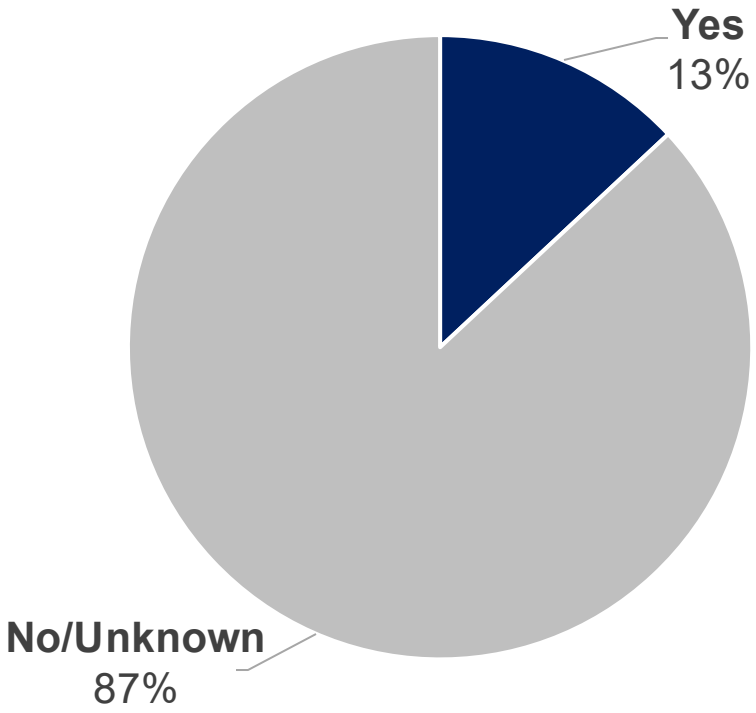
Group/Gang-Related GV Incidents

(Motive for the incident was a group/gang-related conflict)

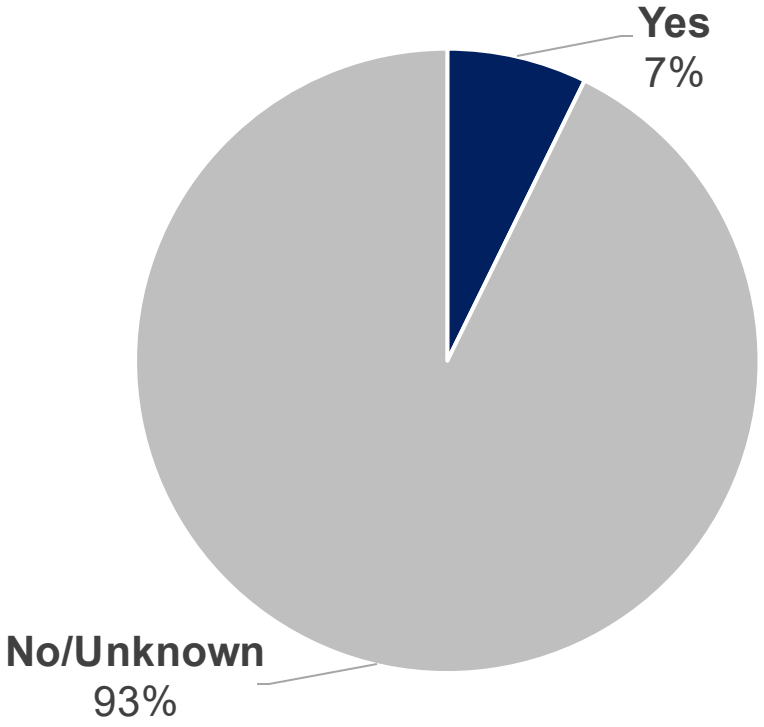


Group/Gang Related Incidents:
Fatal vs. Nonfatal Shootings

Fatal Shootings
n=69

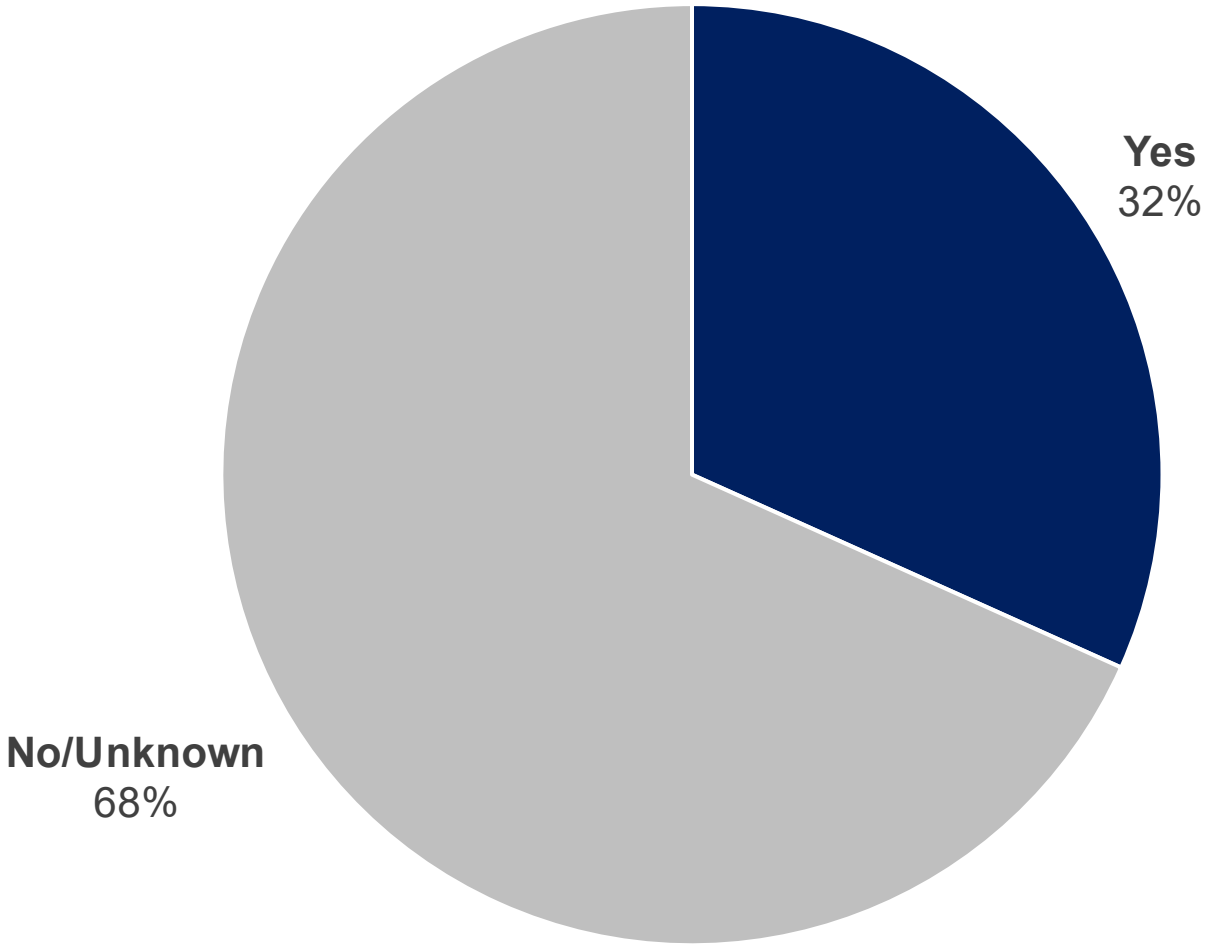


Nonfatal Shootings
n=262



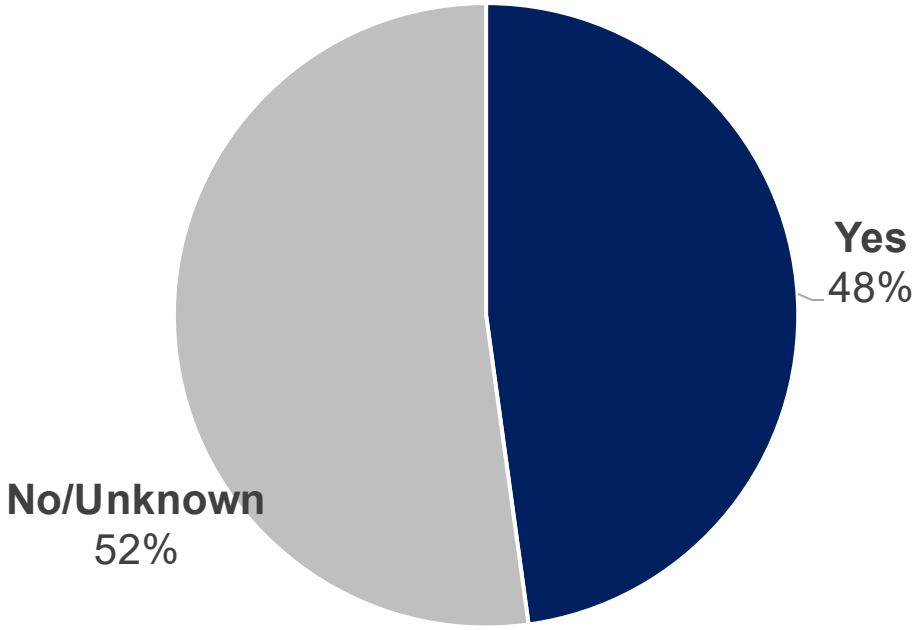
Group/Gang-Member Involvement: GV Incidents

(Victims and/or suspects were group/gang-associated, regardless of incident motive)

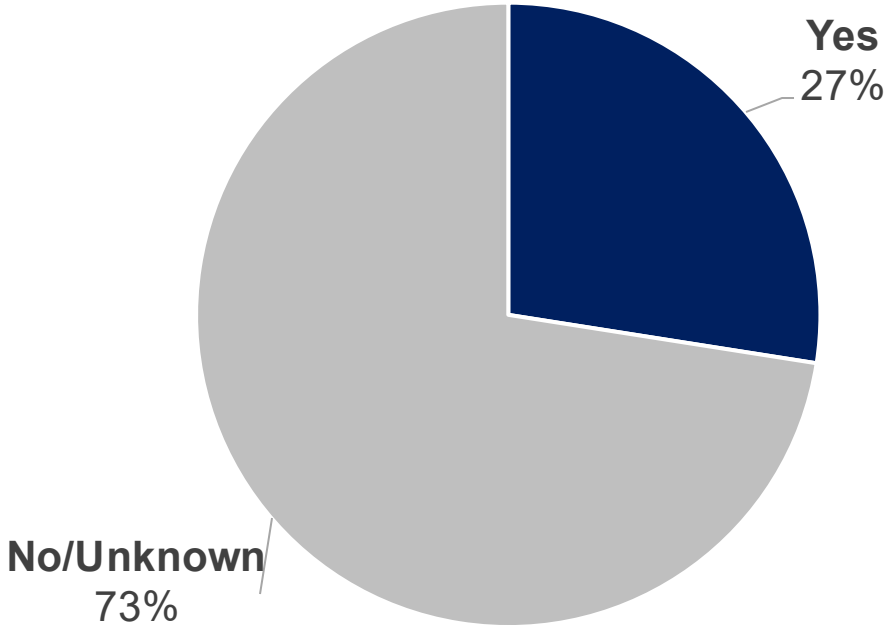


Group/Gang Member Involvement:
Fatal vs. Nonfatal Shootings

Fatal Shootings
n=69

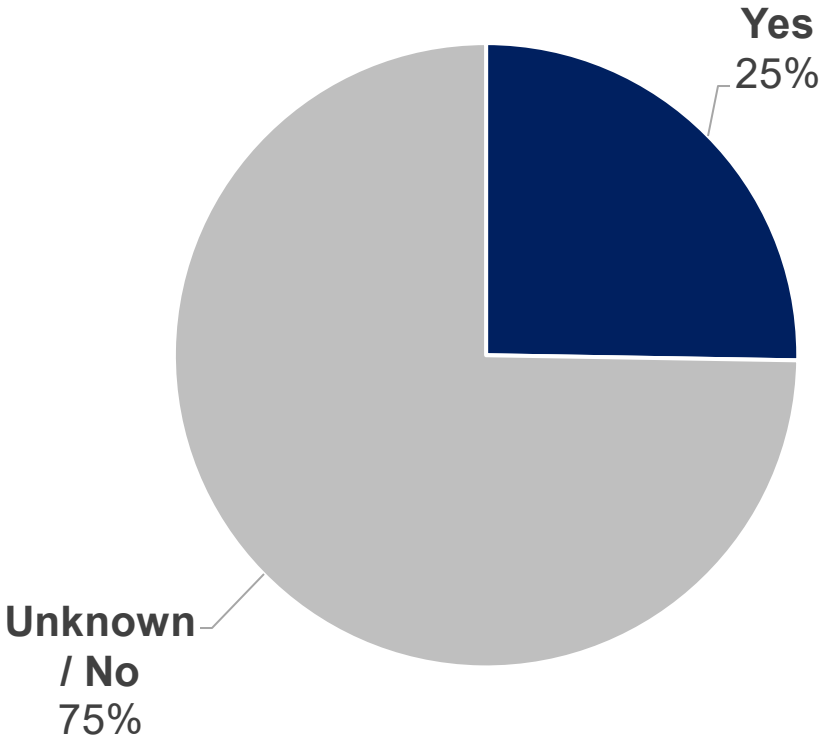


Nonfatal Shootings
n=262

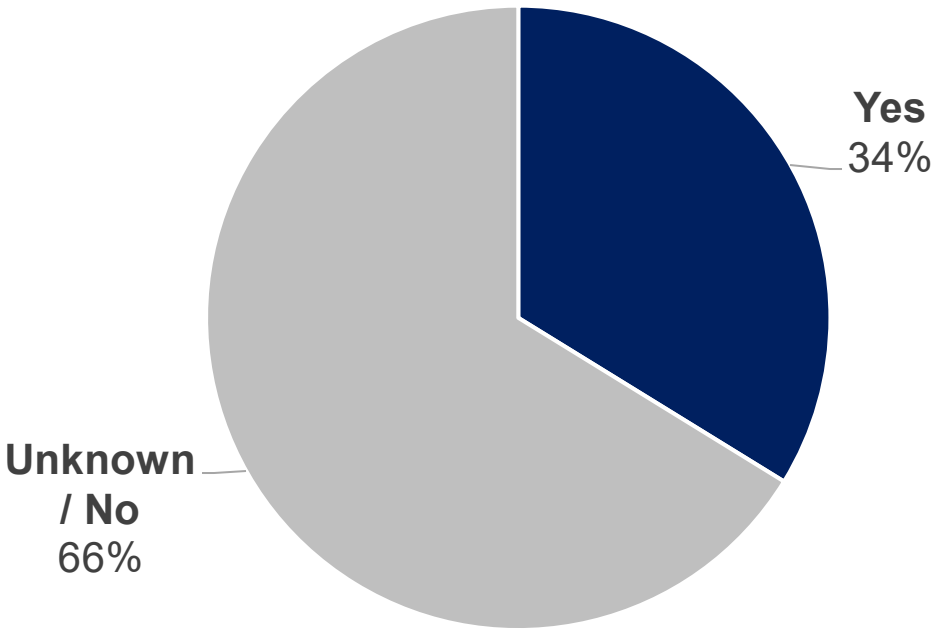


Group/Gang-Member Involvement: Individuals

Victims
n=384



Suspects
n=148



Group Involvement in Gun Violence

- Group member involvement in gun violence incidents is noted as “Unknown” when:
  - There was no known suspect in the case.
    - This prevents classification of the case since it is not possible to know whether or not the suspect was group/gang associated.
  - Detectives could not definitively say that a victim and/or suspect was or was not group-associated.
    - “Unknown” designations are common in violence problem analyses. These designations avoid inflation of “Yes” or “No” categories when an individual’s associations and relationships are unstable and unclear.
      - This is especially common in cities like Hartford that include more informal groups and cliques rather than traditional, structured gangs.

Circumstances: All Gun Violence Incidents

Circumstance	N	All GV Incidents (n = 331)	% Incidents GMI
Personal dispute	**100**	**30.2%**	**27.0%**
Drug-related dispute	**37**	**11.2%**	**27.0%**
Instant dispute	**35**	**11.2%**	**17.1%**
Group-related dispute	**27**	**8.2%**	100%
Robbery	**20**	**6.0%**	30.0%
Drug robbery	**12**	**3.6%**	25.0%
Domestic dispute	**10**	**3.0%**	20.0%
Burglary	**1**	**0.3%**	0.0%
Internal group dispute	**1**	**0.3%**	100%
Other	**1**	**0.3%**	0.0%
Unknown	**87**	**26.3%**	33.3%

Victims were uncooperative in 57% of cases with unknown circumstances.

Circumstances: Fatal Shootings

Circumstance	N	Fatal Shootings (n = 69)	% Incidents GMI
Personal dispute	**32**	**46.4%**	**40.6%**
Group-related dispute	**9**	**13.0%**	**100%**
Instant dispute	**8**	**11.6%**	**25.0%**
Drug-related dispute	**6**	**8.7%**	83.3%
Drug robbery	**4**	**5.8%**	50.0%
Robbery	**3**	**4.4%**	0.0%
Domestic dispute	**2**	**2.9%**	0.0%
Unknown	**5**	**7.3%**	60.0%

Circumstances: Nonfatal Shootings

Circumstance	N	Nonfatal Shootings (n = 262)	% Incidents GMI
Personal dispute	**68**	**26.0%**	**20.6%**
Drug-related dispute	**31**	**11.8%**	**16.1%**
Instant dispute	**27**	**10.3%**	**14.8%**
Group-related dispute	**18**	**6.9%**	100%
Robbery	**17**	**6.5%**	35.3%
Domestic dispute	**8**	**3.1%**	25.0%
Drug robbery	**8**	**3.1%**	12.5%
Burglary	**1**	**0.4%**	0.0%
Internal group dispute	**1**	**0.4%**	100%
Other	**1**	**0.4%**	0.0%
Unknown	**82**	**31.3%**	31.7%

Summary – GV Incidents

- About 83% of all homicides in Hartford from 2022-2024 were gun homicides while an additional 11% were committed using knives.
- About 8% of gun violence incidents involved motives relating solely to group/gang-related conflicts.
- Overall, at least 32% of homicides involved group/gang members as victims, suspects, or both.
  - At least 25% of victims and about 34% of suspects were known to be group/gang-associated.
- Regardless of group/gang member involvement, most homicides in Hartford evolved from ongoing personal disputes between known individuals (30%), drug-related disputes (11%), and sudden disputes (11%).

Summary – Fatal vs. Nonfatal Shootings

- About 48% of fatal shootings involved group/gang members relative to 27% of nonfatal shootings.
- Fatal shootings were more likely to result from interpersonal disputes (46%) when compared to nonfatal shootings (26%).
- A greater proportion of fatal shootings resulted from group/gang conflicts (13%) relative to nonfatal shootings (7%).
- The shooting motive was more likely to be unknown in nonfatal shootings (31%) which suffered from low rates of victim cooperation. Victims were uncooperative in at least 57% of those cases with unknown circumstances.

HIGH-RISK GROUPS AND NETWORKS

Introduction

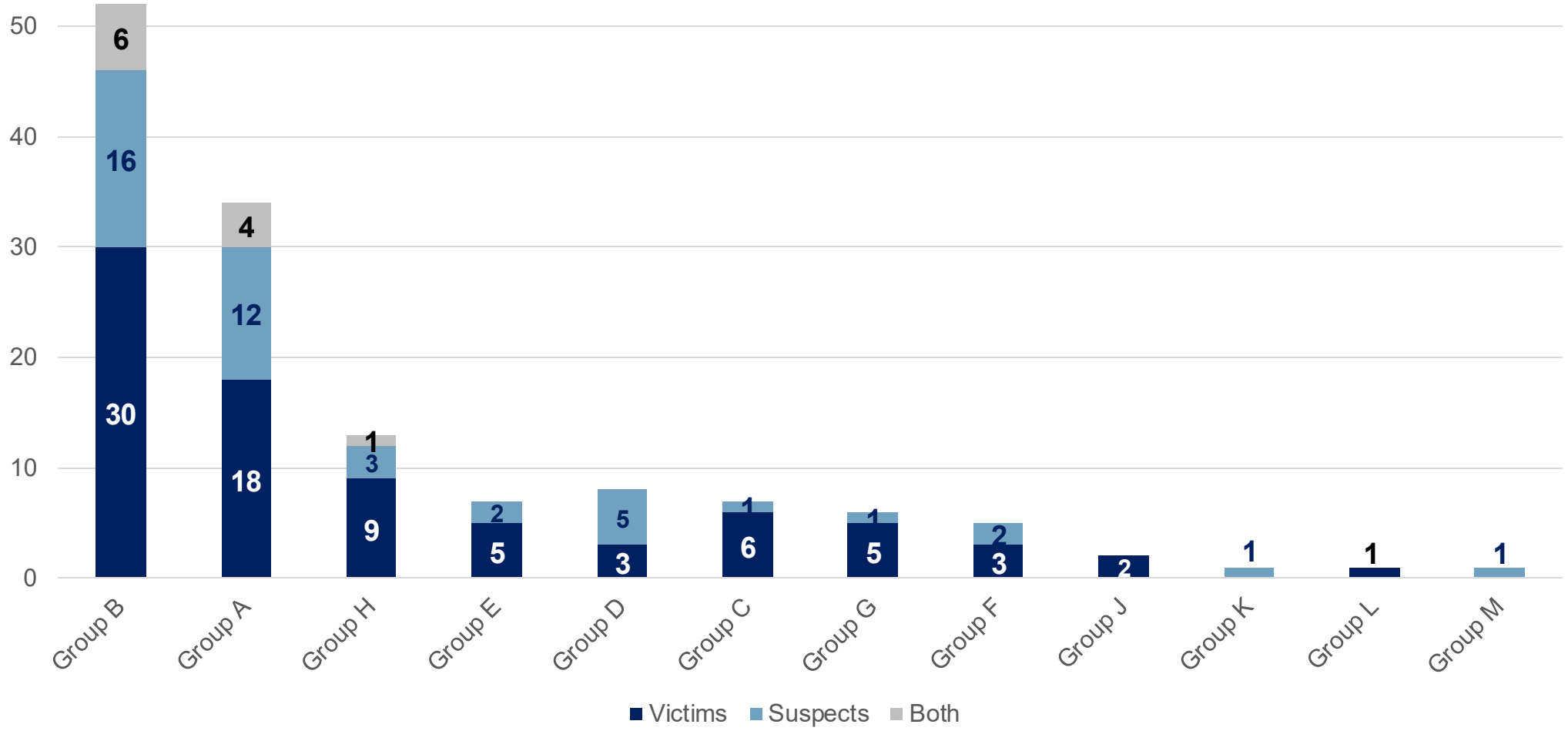
- This section presents information about active high-risk violent networks in Hartford.
- HPD personnel identified **9 active groups/gangs/crews** in the city.
  - Most of these groups are not traditional groups/gangs. Instead, they reflect loose associations between criminally active individuals who are active or residing in particular neighborhoods.
    - Though these informal crews sometimes have predictable conflicts with other areas (e.g., Group A vs. Group B), it is important to note that:
      - Designations of individual group associations are largely created and applied by law enforcement.
      - The individuals associated with these groups are unlikely to formally rep or claim these groups.
      - The social networks between and within these groups are extremely fluid and unstable.

Identified Groups in Hartford

Group (Anonymized)	Range of Associates	Conflicts
Group A*	150-200	Group B, Group E
Group C	20	Group B, Group E
Group D*	15-25	Group E, Group B
Group B*	150-200	Group A
Group E*	50	Group A, Group D, Other MV theft groups
Group F*	10-15	Group A, Group C
Group G	50-75	
Group H	50-75	
Group I*	25	

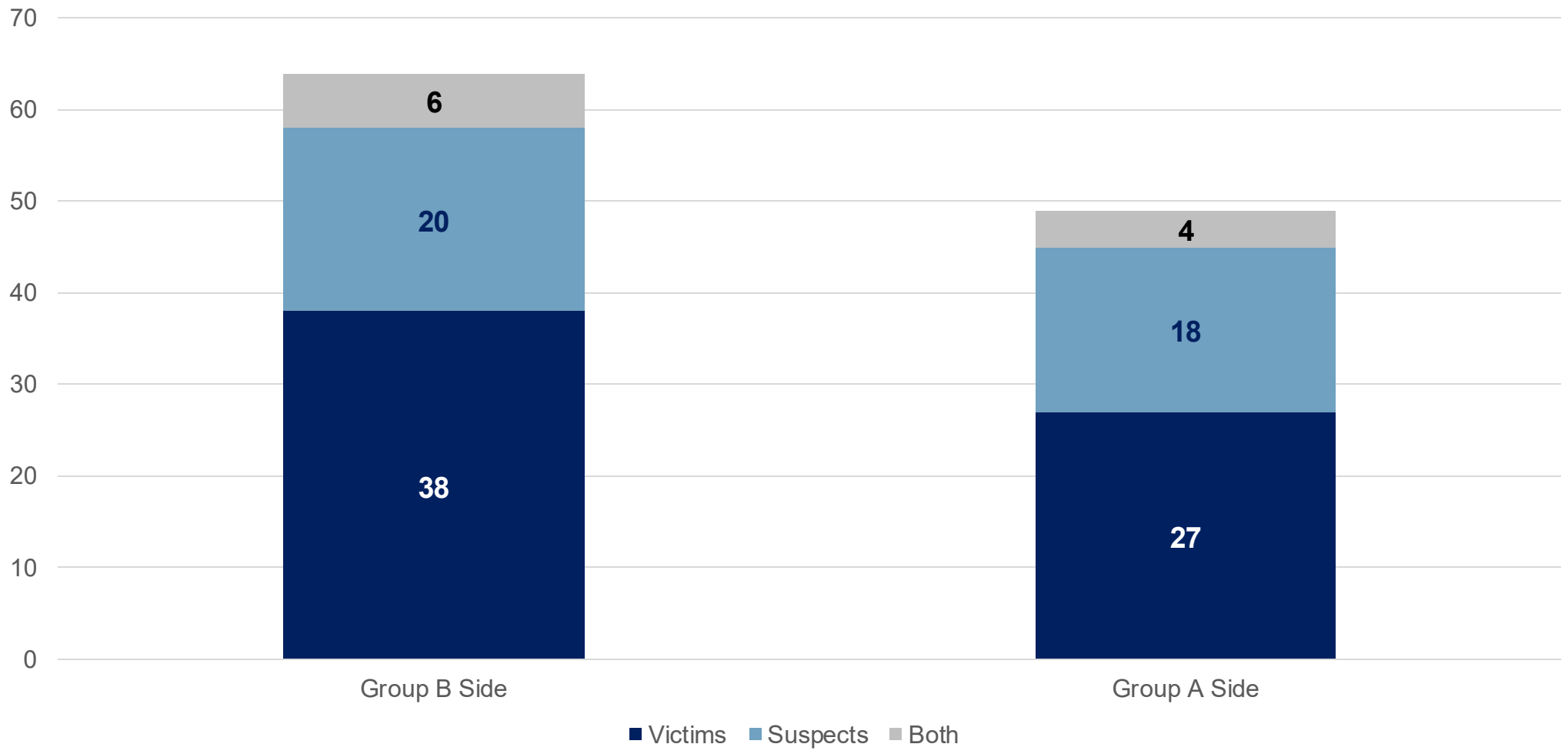
*Non-traditional group/gang. Reflects loose associations among informal criminal cliques with somewhat stable allegiances to areas/neighborhoods.

Group Involvement in Gun Violence



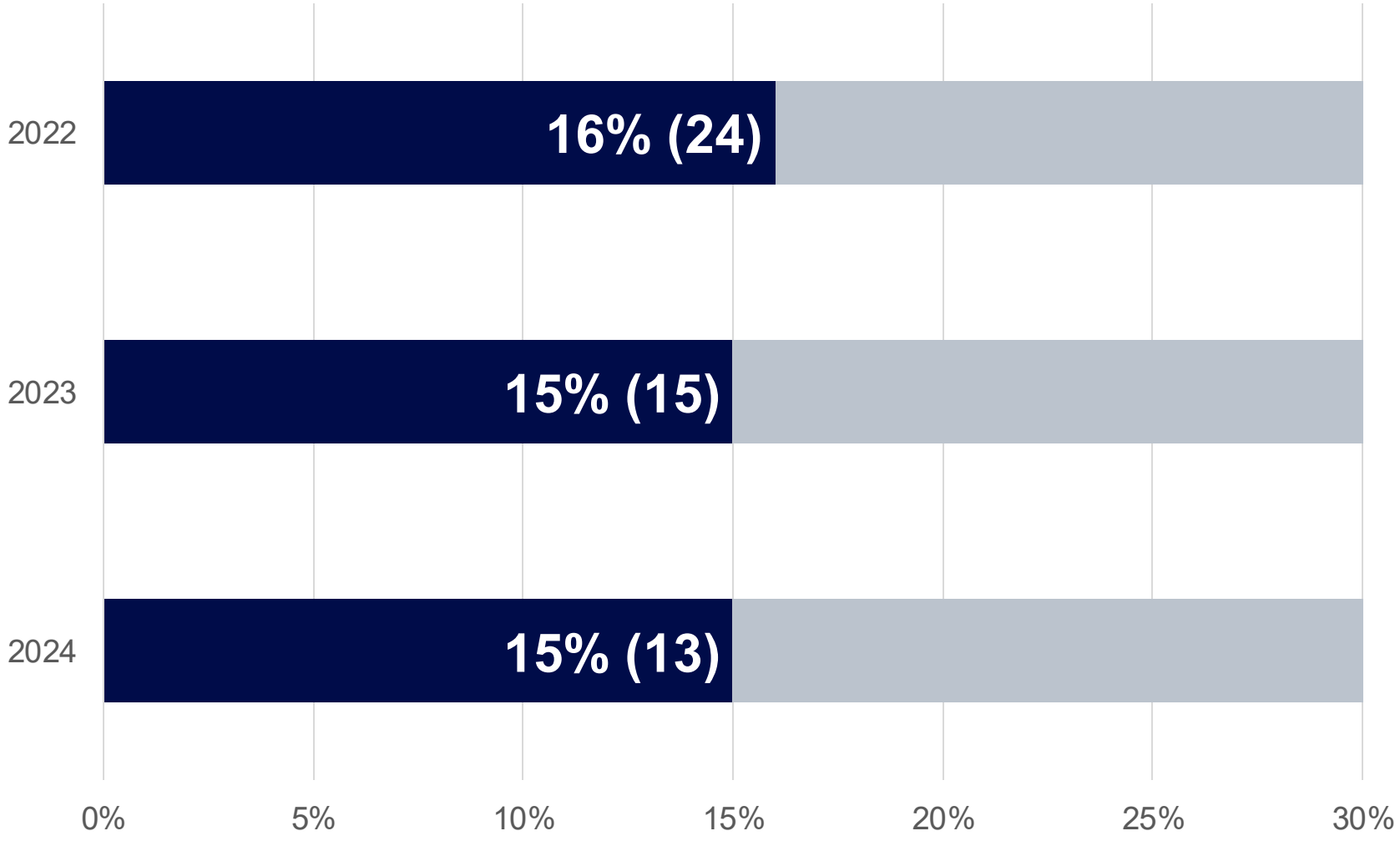
*Groups J-M were not identified as being present in Hartford and/or active in violence during this sample time period.

Group Involvement in Gun Violence (Group A vs. Group B)

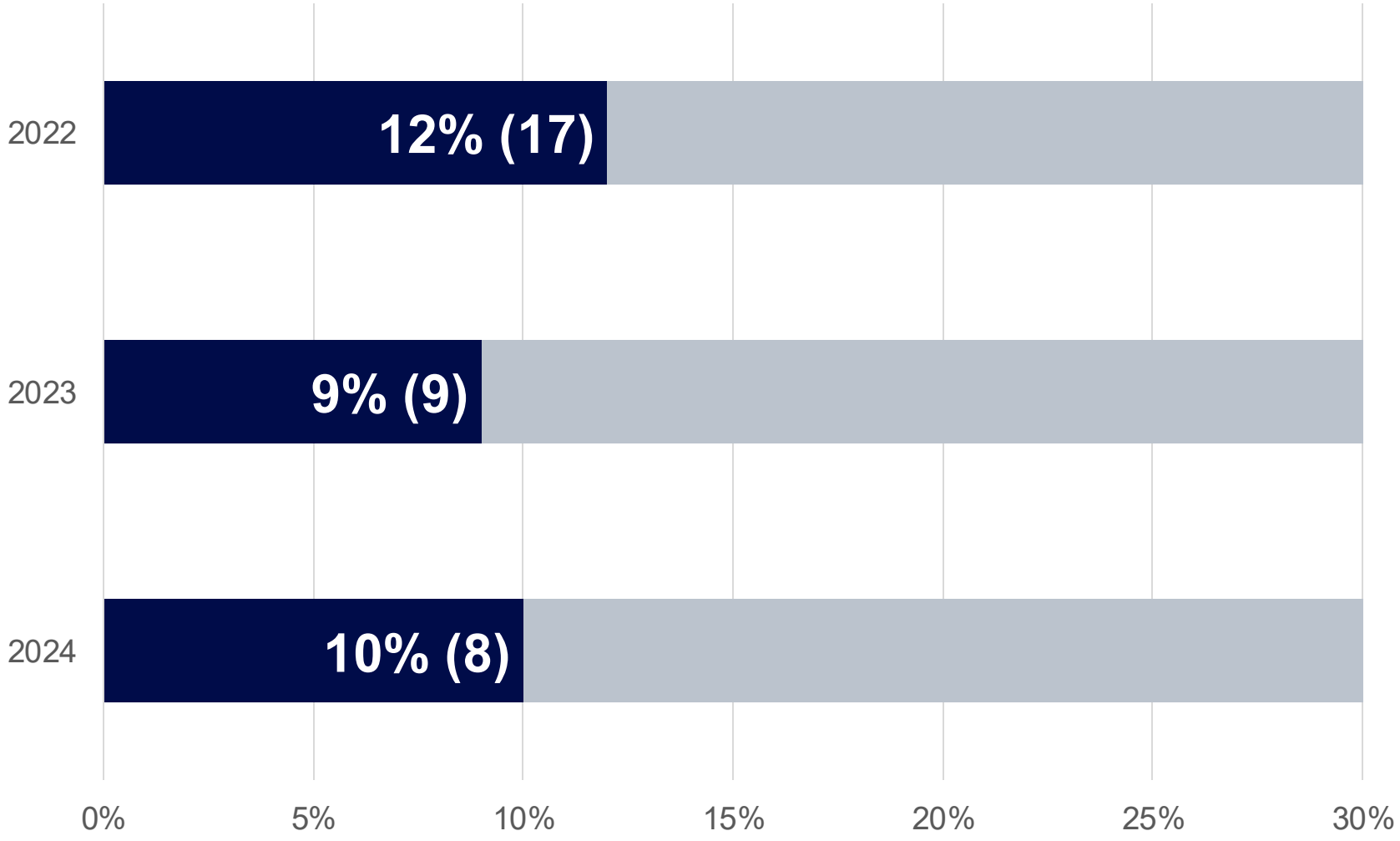


Group B side combines Group B, Group E, and Group F. Group A side combines Group A, Group C, and Group D.

Involvement in Gun Violence by Year: Group B



Involvement in Gun Violence by Year: Group A

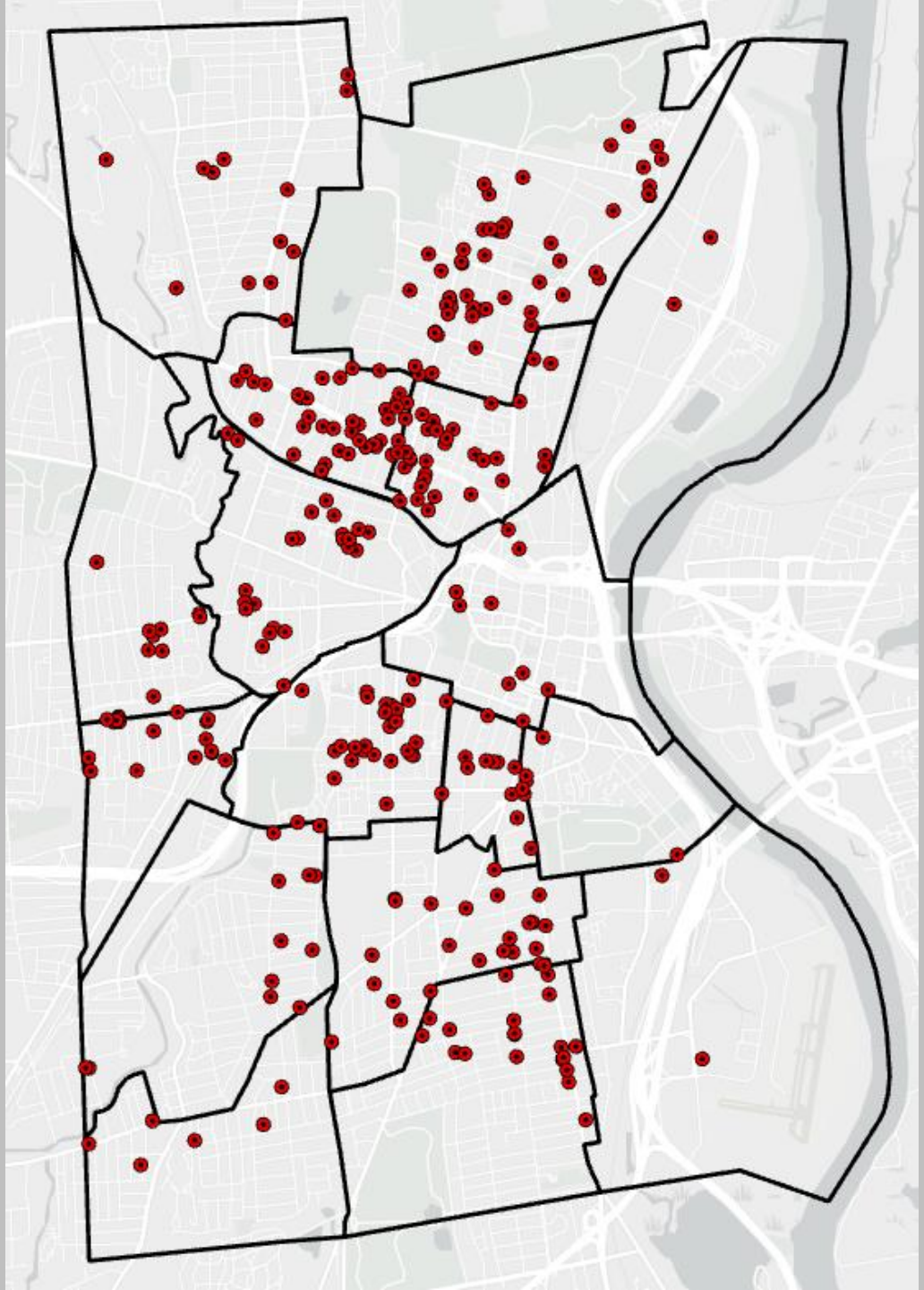


Summary

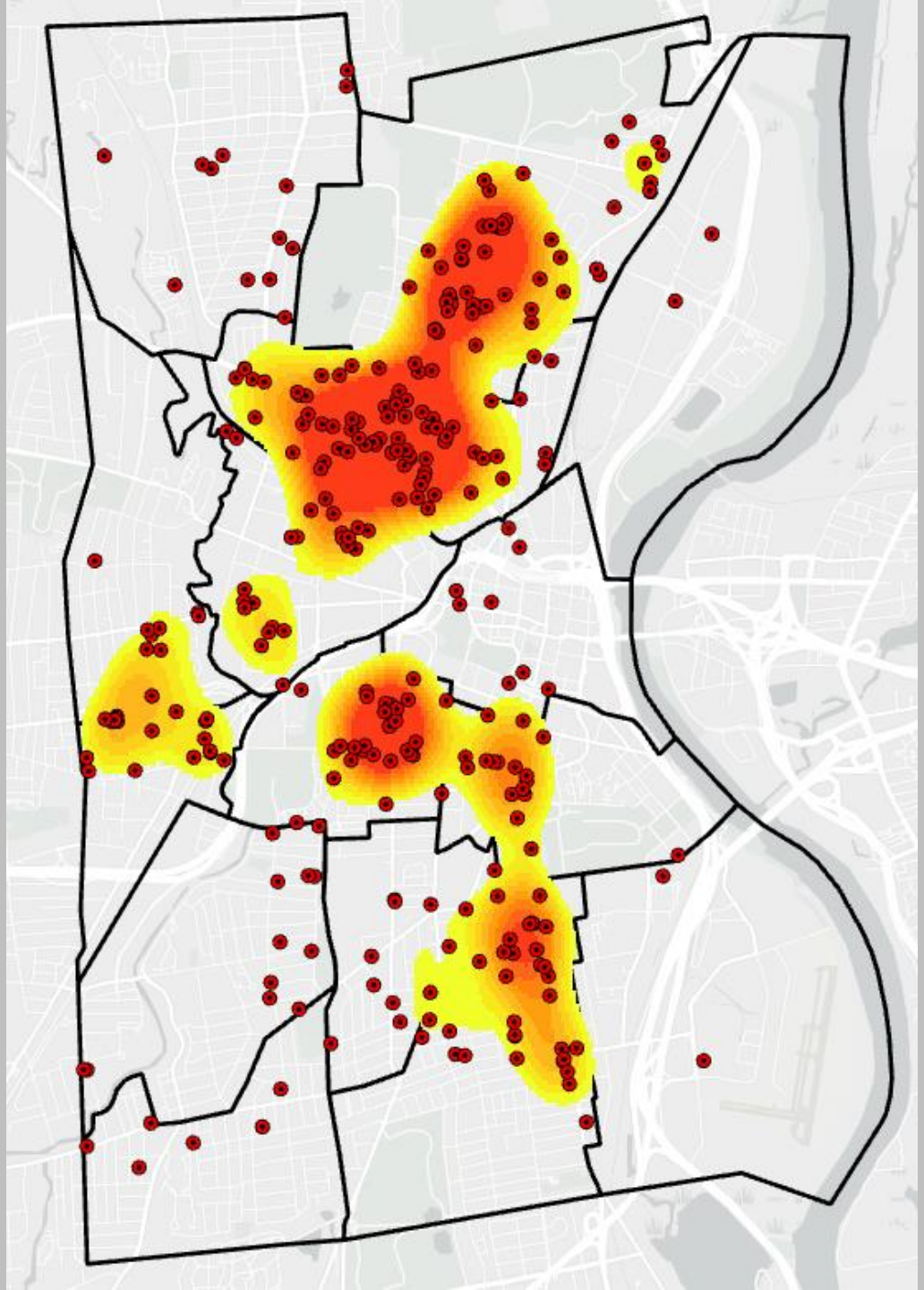
- The largest and most violently active groups in Hartford are Group B and Group A.
  - Group B involvement is substantially higher than any other group, and its members are involved in at least 15% of gun violence incidents each year.
  - Group B and Group A groups were involved in a similar share of gun violence incidents overall each year. However, there was a 46% decrease in the number of gun violence incidents involving Group B members, and there was a 53% decrease in the number of gun violence incidents involving Group A members.
  - Members of these Group A- and Group B-allied groups total an estimated 395-510 members, or about 0.4% of the city's population.
  - Both groups include a large number of gun violence victims and shooters, which significantly increases risk of violence involvement among close contacts in their social circles.

SPATIAL ANALYSIS

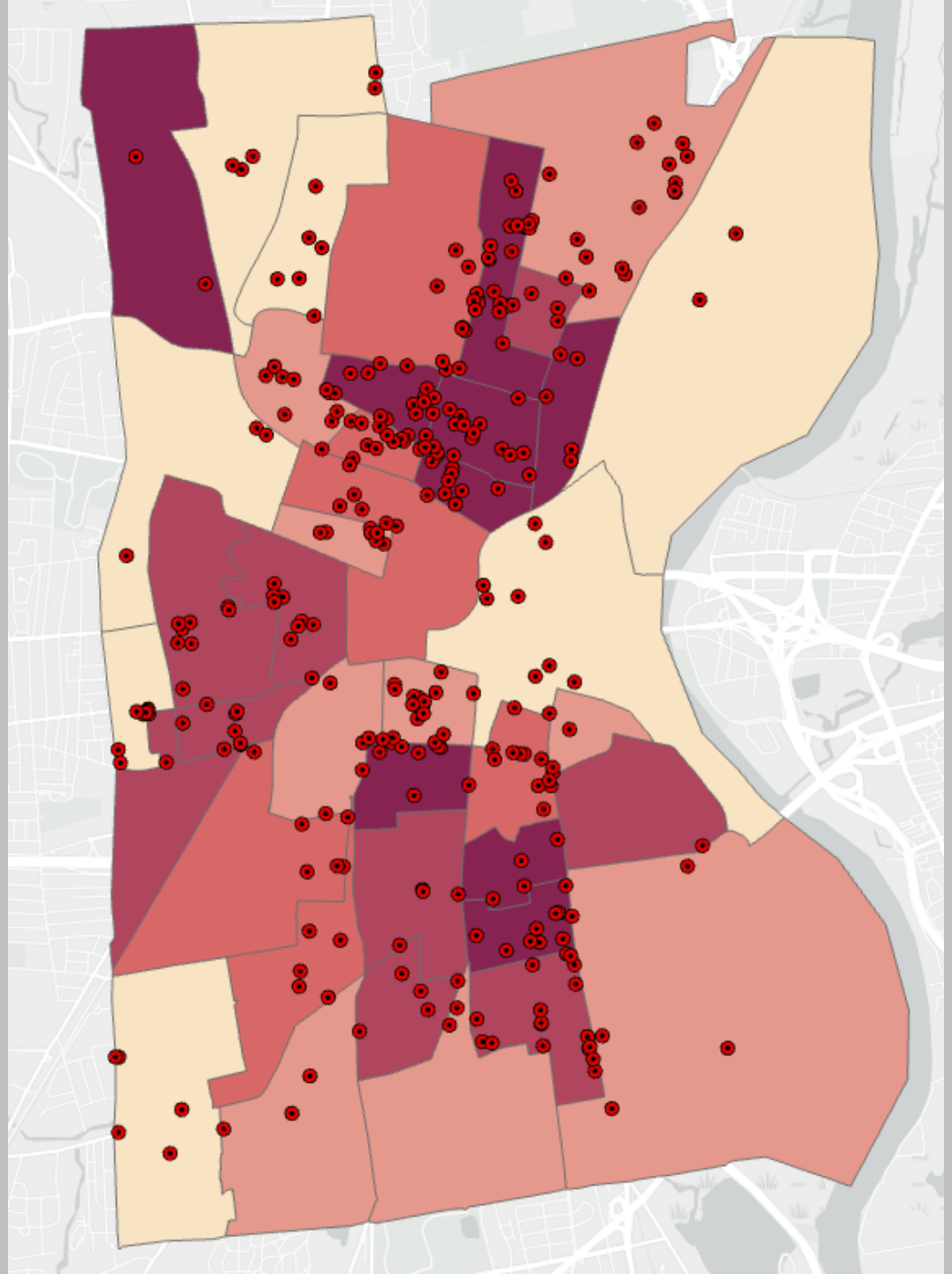
Fatal & Nonfatal Shootings: 2022 - 2024



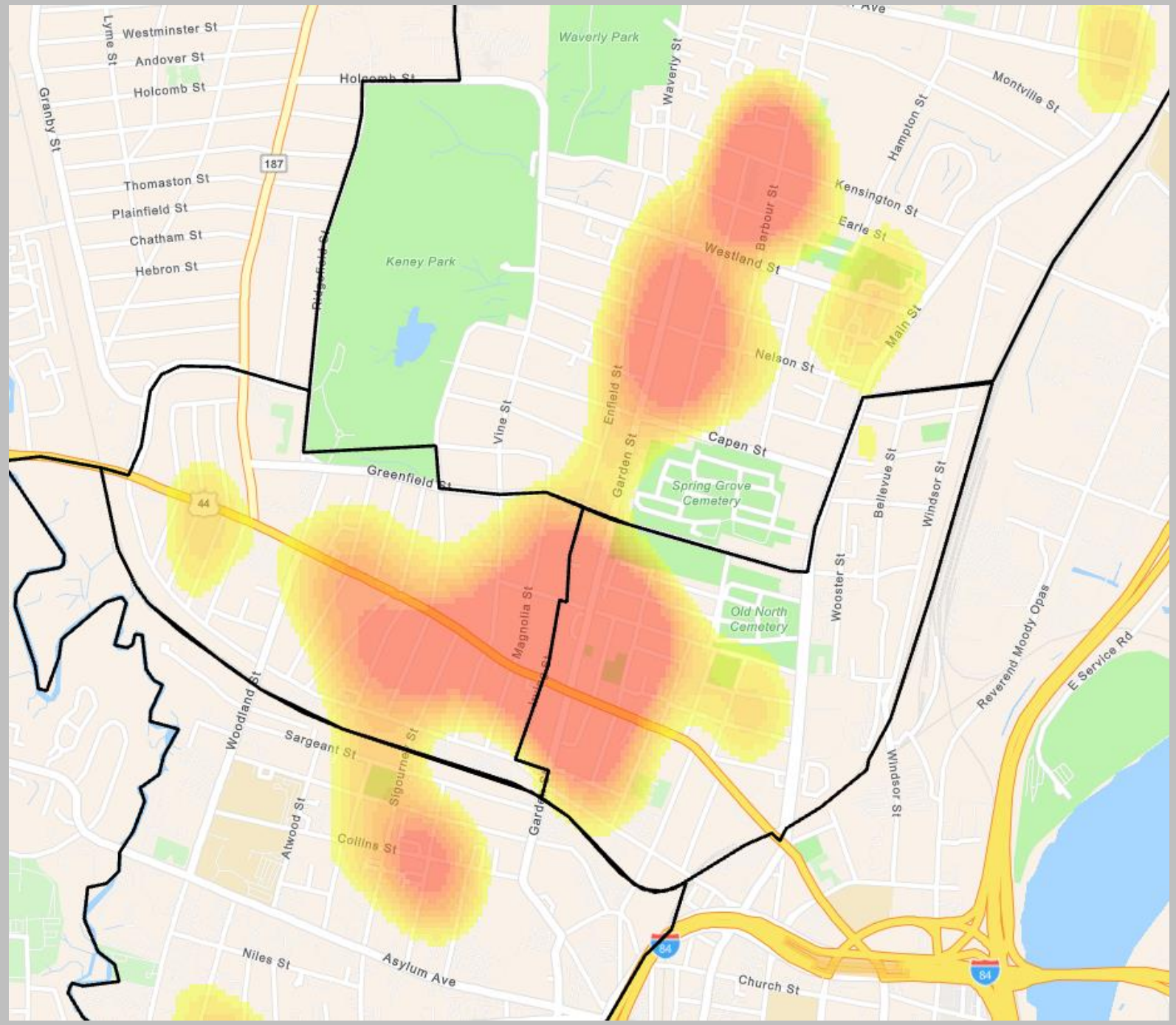
Fatal & Nonfatal Shooting Hot Spots: 2022 - 2024



Fatal & Nonfatal Shootings Over Poverty Level (Census Tracts)

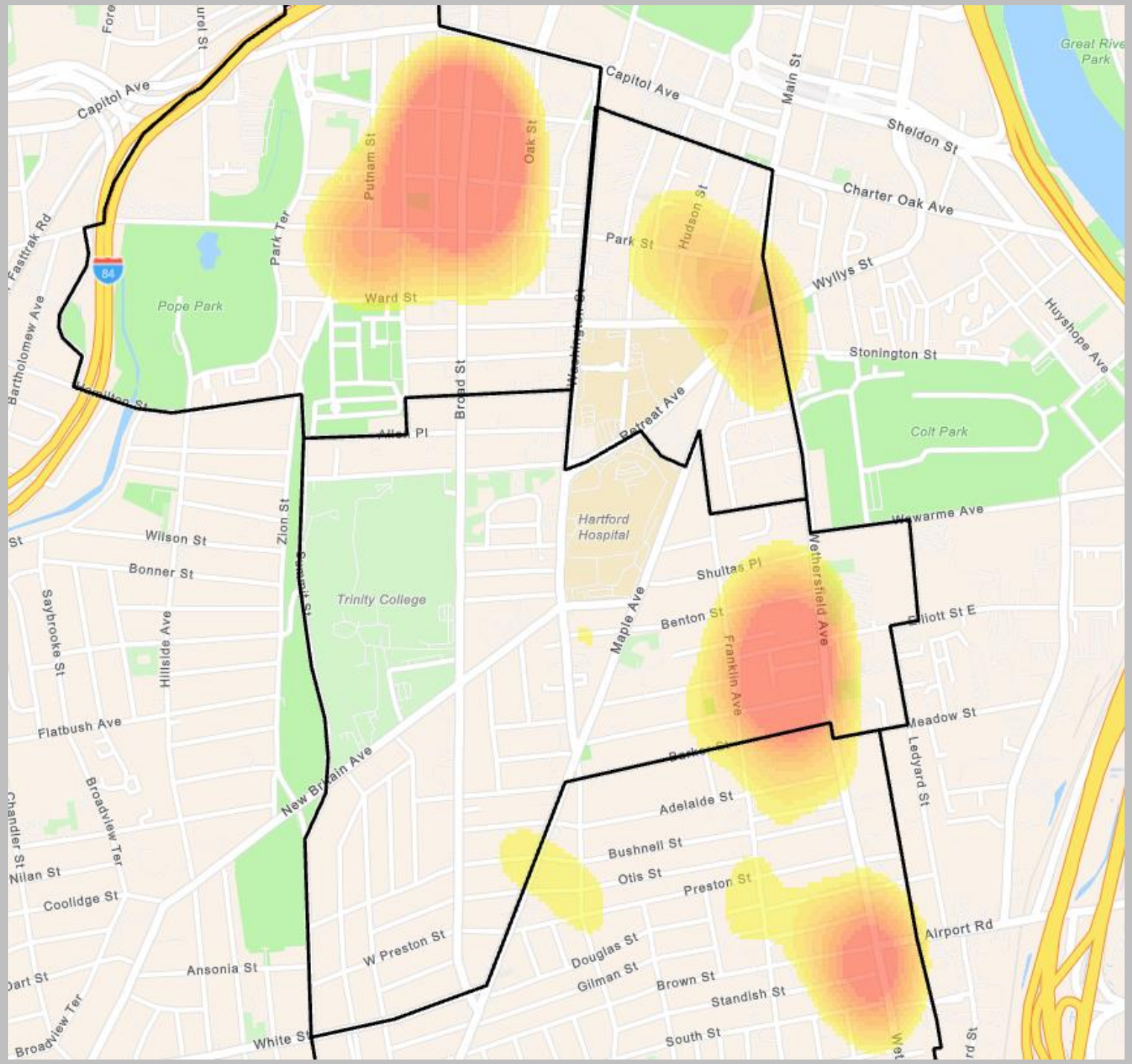


Fatal & Nonfatal Shooting Hot Spots - North:
2022 - 2024

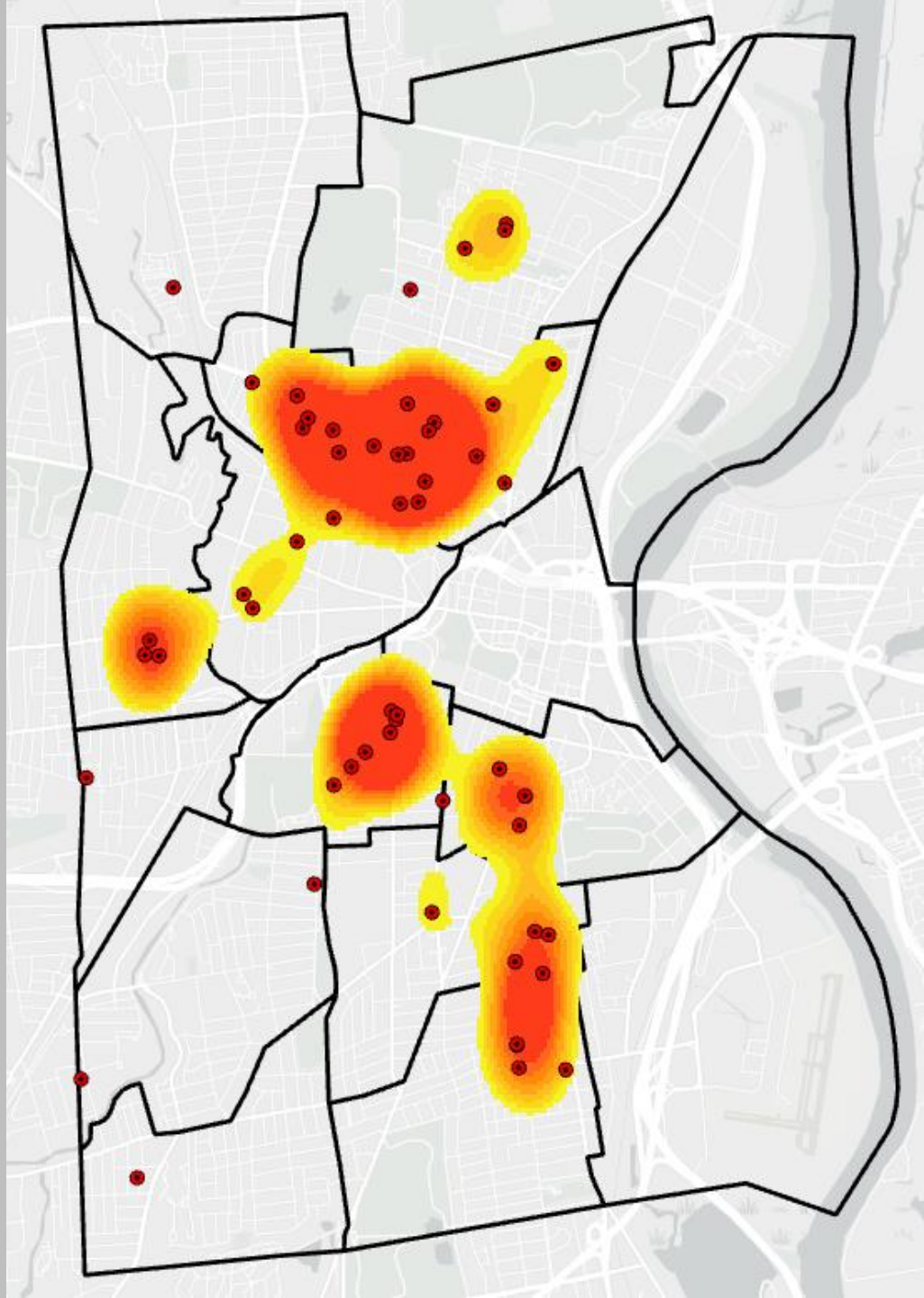


Fatal & Nonfatal Shooting Hot Spots - North:

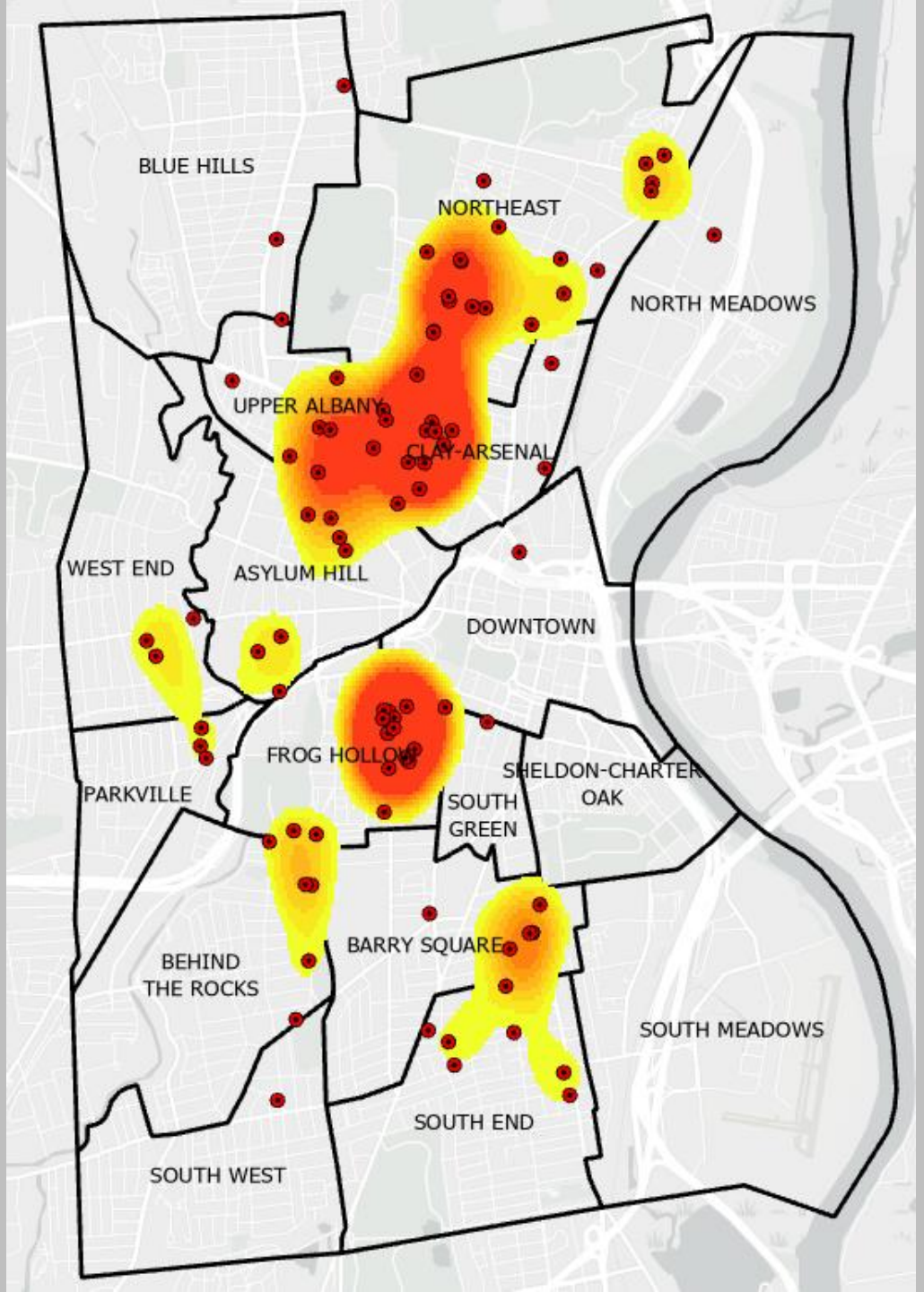
2022 - 2024



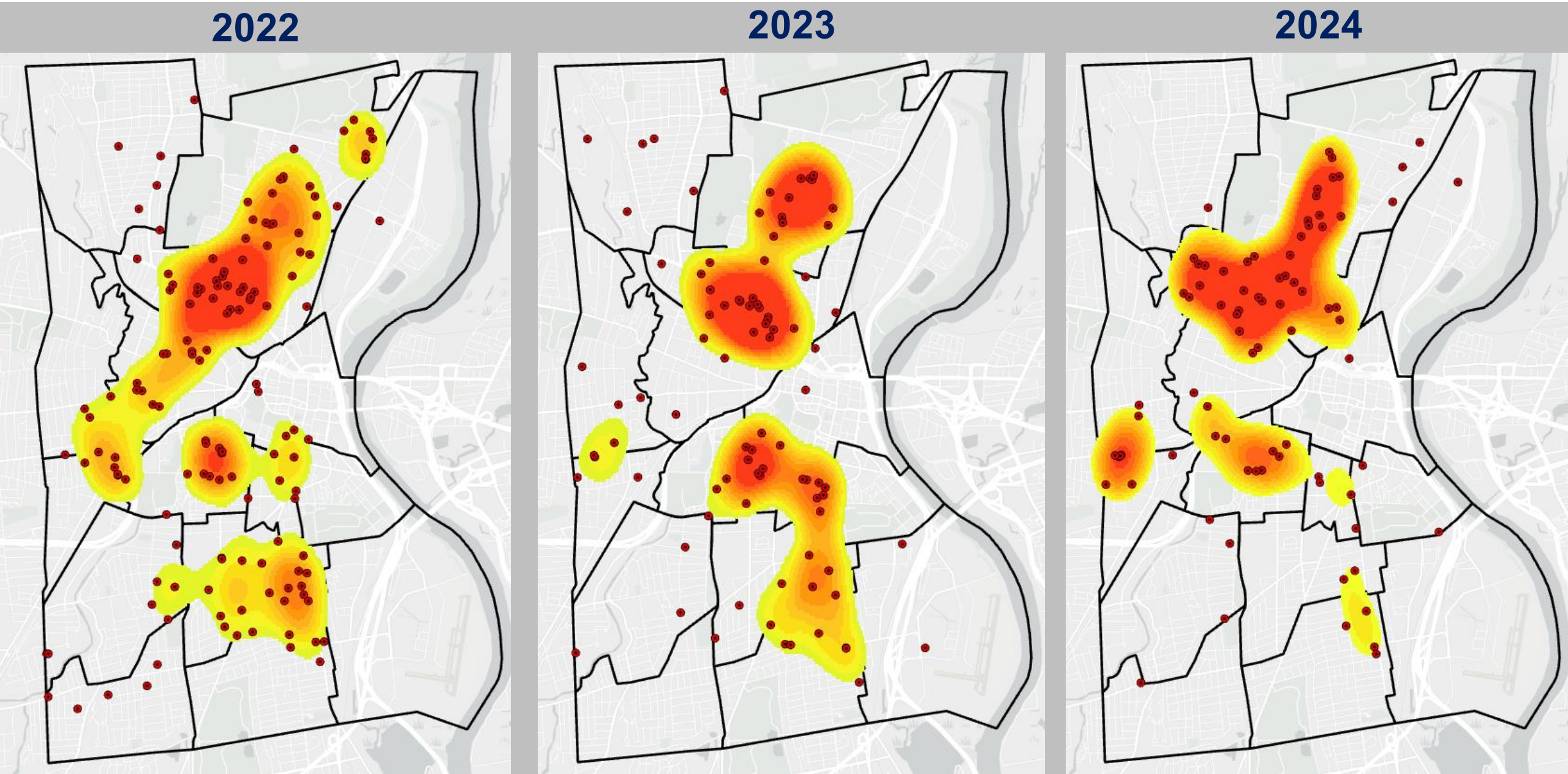
Drug-Related Shooting Hot Spots: 2022 - 2024



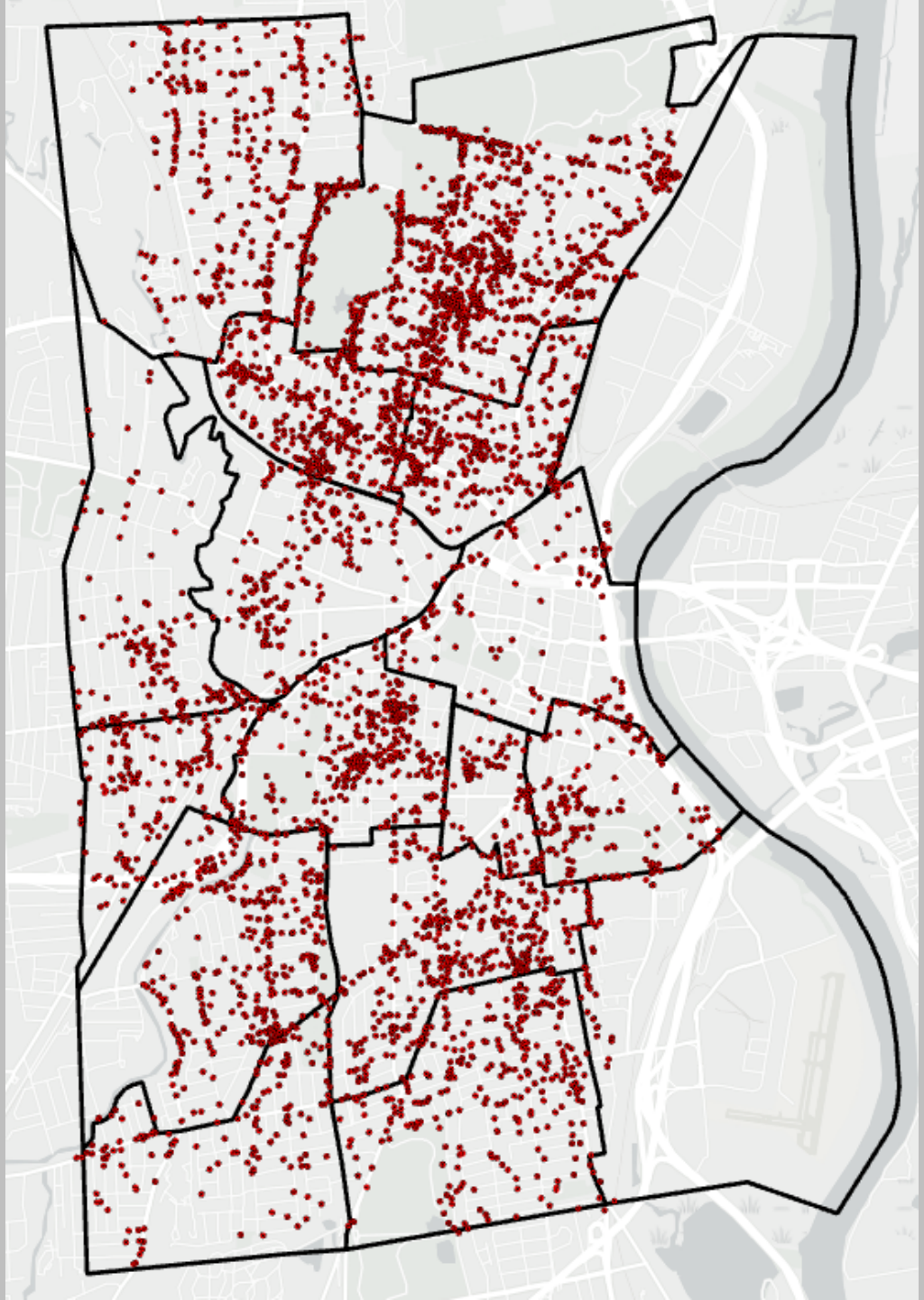
Group-Involved Shooting Hot Spots: 2022 - 2024



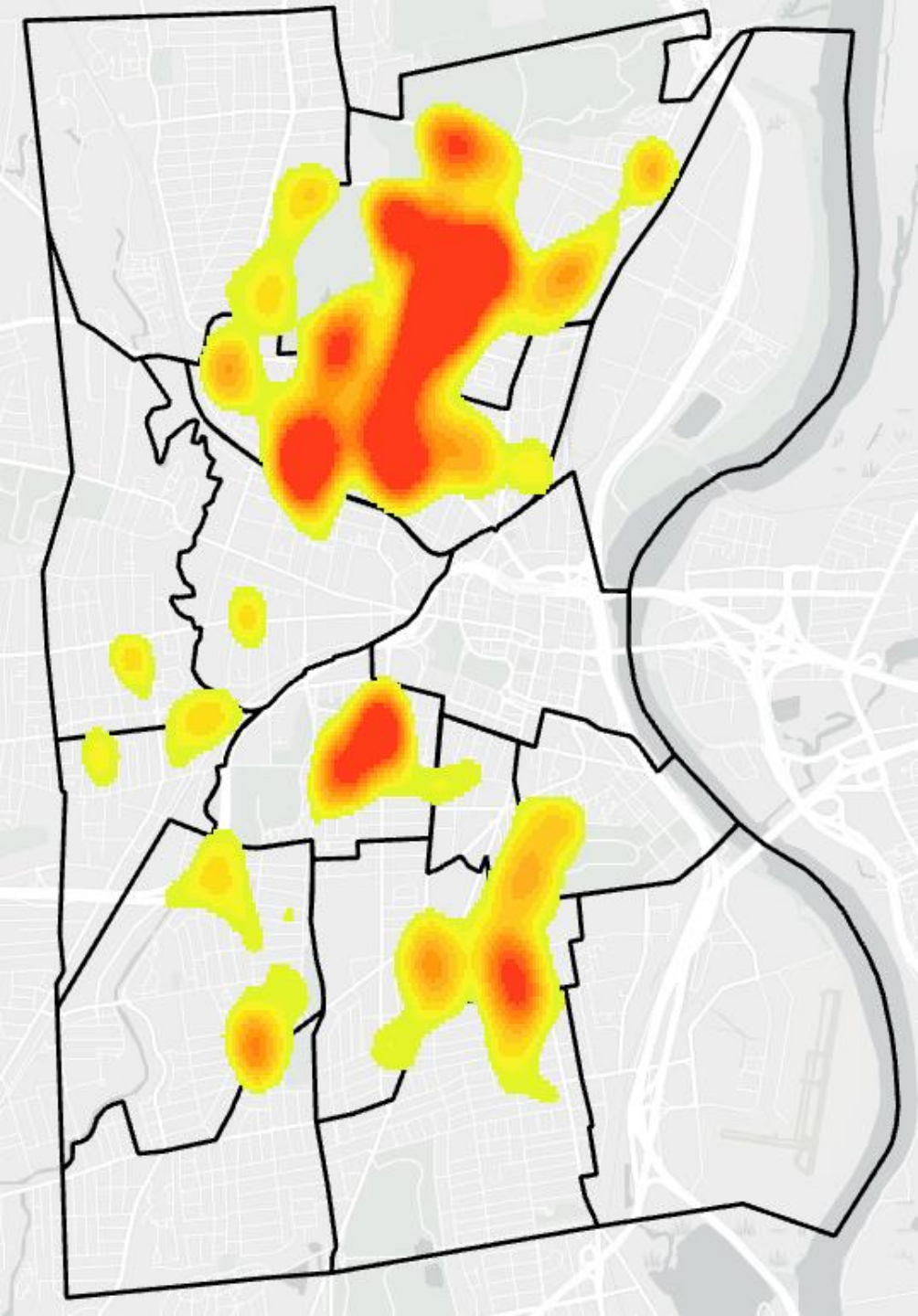
Fatal & Nonfatal Shootings by Year



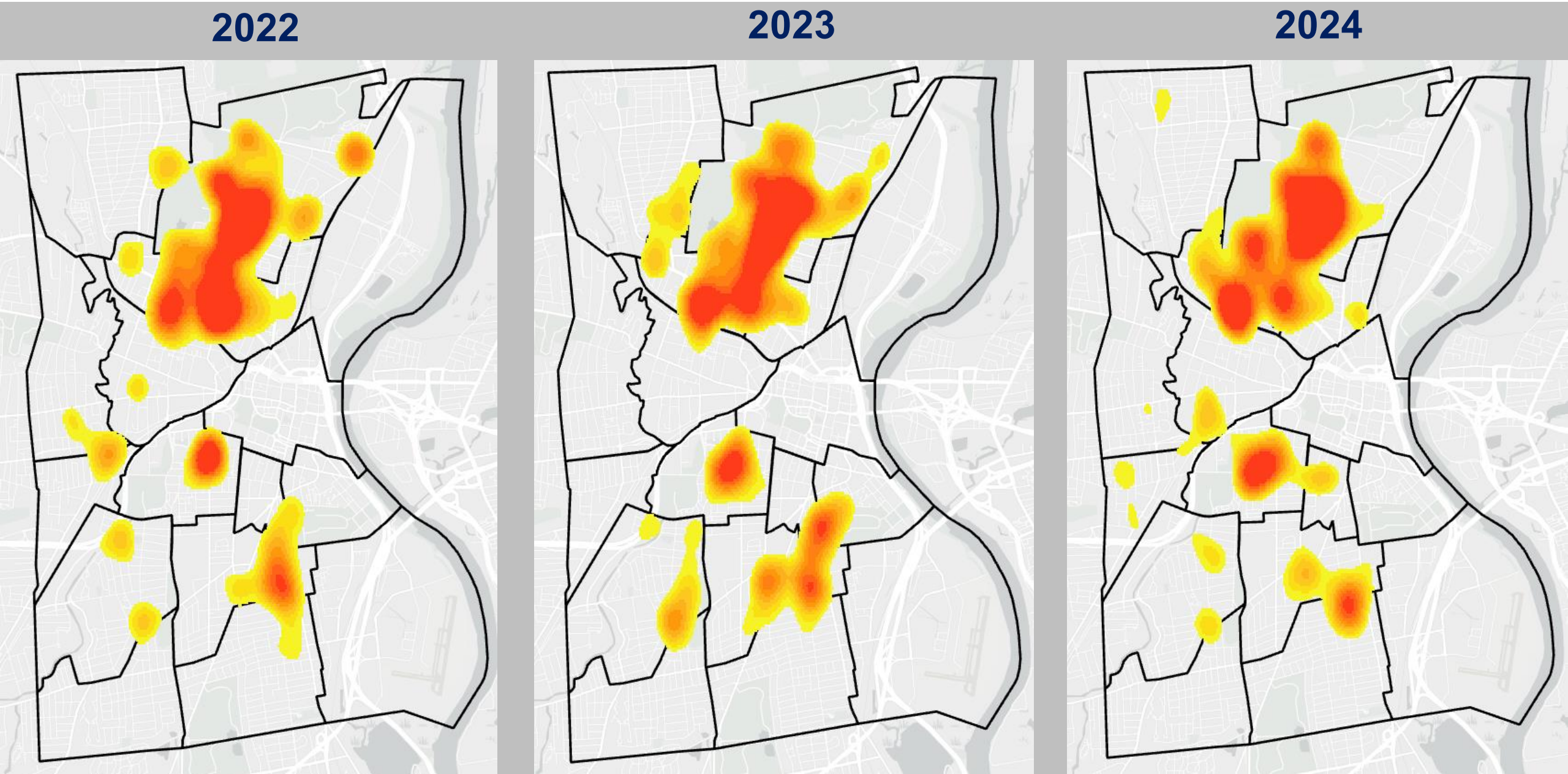
ShotSpotter Activations: 2022 - 2024



ShotSpotter Activation Hot Spots: 2022 - 2024



ShotSpotter Activation Hot Spots by Year



Summary

- Maps of homicides and shootings show incident occurrences as clustering in relatively stable locations in North neighborhoods (Asylum Hill, Clay Arsenal, Upper Albany, Northeast) and South neighborhoods (Frog Hollow, South Green, Barry Square, South End).
    - Hot spots cover just over about 5.2 square miles, or about 30% of Hartford's land area.
    - About 76% of fatal and nonfatal shootings from 2022-2024 occurred within these identified hot spots.

GUN VIOLENCE ANALYSIS

Time Period Comparisons

GV Victims by Year: Demographics

	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
	N=140	N=210	N=173	N=169	N=119	N=96
Male	92.1%	87.1%	88.4%	87.6%	90.8%	88.5%
Black	61.4%	61.2%	67.1%	68.1%	56.8%	64.2%
Hispanic	35.0%	34.9%	32.4%	30.2%	42.4%	32.6%
Average Age	28.8	29.4	30.7	30.7	32.2	29.8
17 & under	2.9%	7.1%	6.4%	4.7%	10.1%	8.3%
18-24	29.3%	31.4%	22.0%	28.4%	22.7%	30.2%
25-34	45.7%	37.6%	45.1%	35.5%	27.7%	29.2%

GV Suspects by Year: Demographics

	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
	N=50	N=61	N=72	N=79	N=36	N=33
Male	96.0%	96.7%	95.8%	98.7%	100%	89.7%
Black	56.3%	69.5%	67.1%	77.9%	70.8%	59.1%
Hispanic	43.8%	30.5%	31.4%	22.1%	29.2%	40.9%
Average Age	27.6	27.6	26.6	28.9	30.3	31.9
17 & under	6.8%	8.2%	0.0%	4.0%	11.4%	6.7%
18-24	29.6%	31.2%	54.4%	31.6%	14.3%	20.0%
25-34	43.2%	47.5%	30.9%	43.4%	42.9%	33.3%

GV Incidents: Circumstance

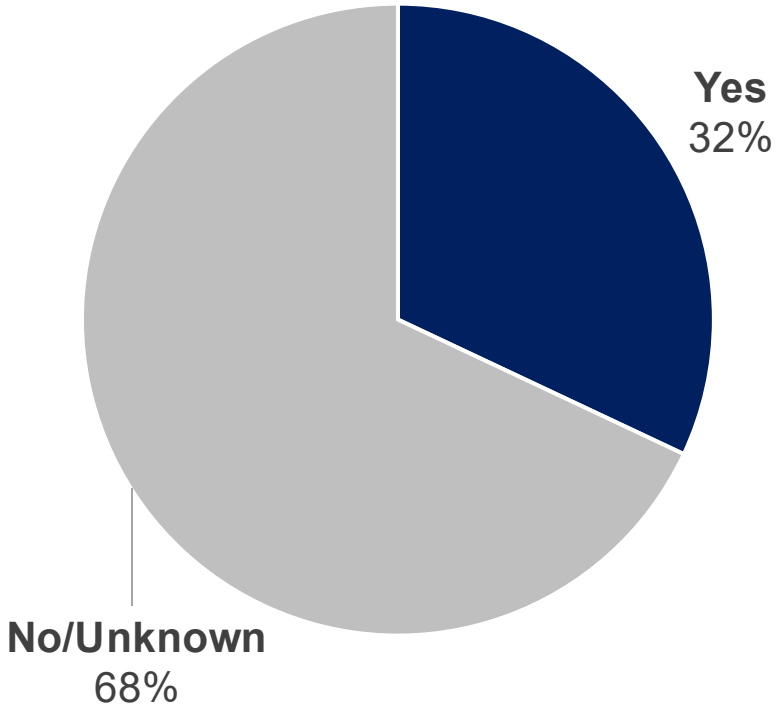
	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024
Circumstance	**N=120**	**N=186**	**N=155**	**N=146**	**N=101**	**N=84**
Personal dispute	20.0%	20.9%	25.2%	**34.9%**	**30.7%**	**32.1%**
Group-related dispute	9.1%	9.7%	7.7%	11.0%	5.9%	7.1%
Drug-related dispute	15.8%	18.3%	21.3%	**10.3%**	**12.9%**	**10.7%**
Instant dispute	6.7%	4.8%	**16.1%**	9.6%	12.9%	10.7%
Robbery/Carjacking	3.3%	2.7%	3.2%	4.1%	5.9%	**9.5%**
Drug robbery	5.0%	1.1%	1.9%	4.8%	3.0%	2.4%
Domestic/family dispute	2.5%	1.6%	3.2%	2.7%	2.0%	4.8%
Other	0.0%	0.0%	1.9%	0.7%	0.0%	0.0%
Unknown	37.5%	40.3%	19.4%	21.9%	27.7%	32.1%

Note: Text colors indicate statistically significant **increases** or **decreases**.

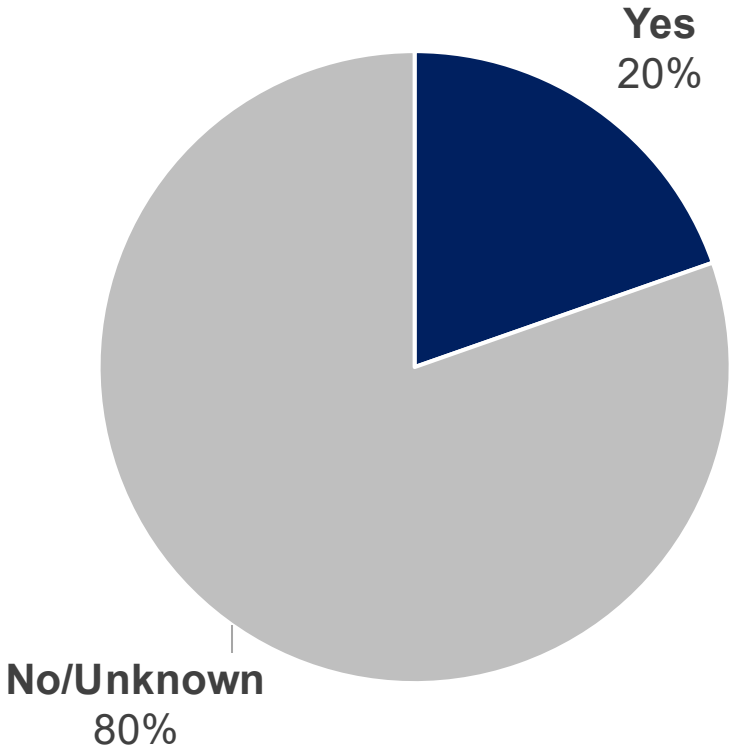
GV Incidents: Drug-Related Cases

(Incidents involved drug related disputes or drug robberies)

2019-2021
N=461



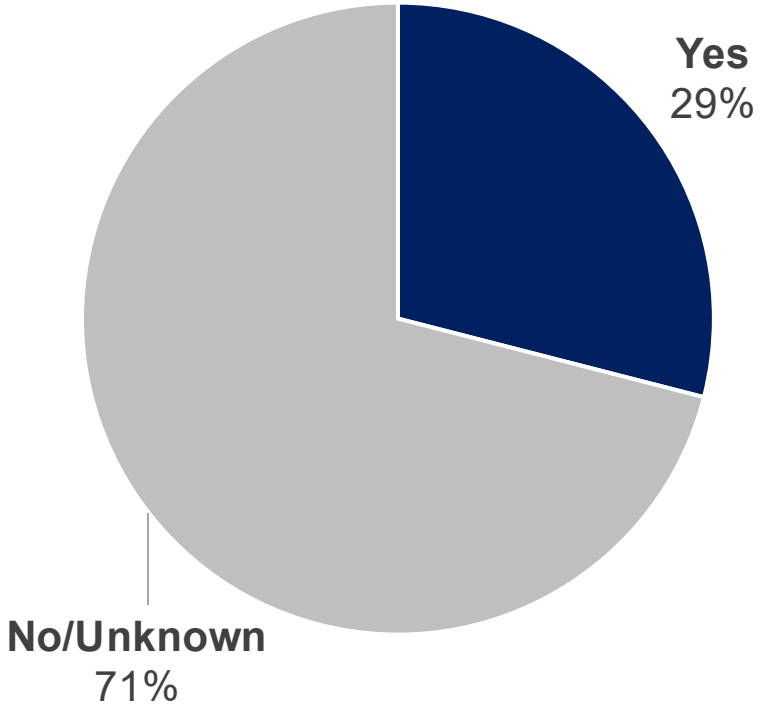
2022-2024
N=331



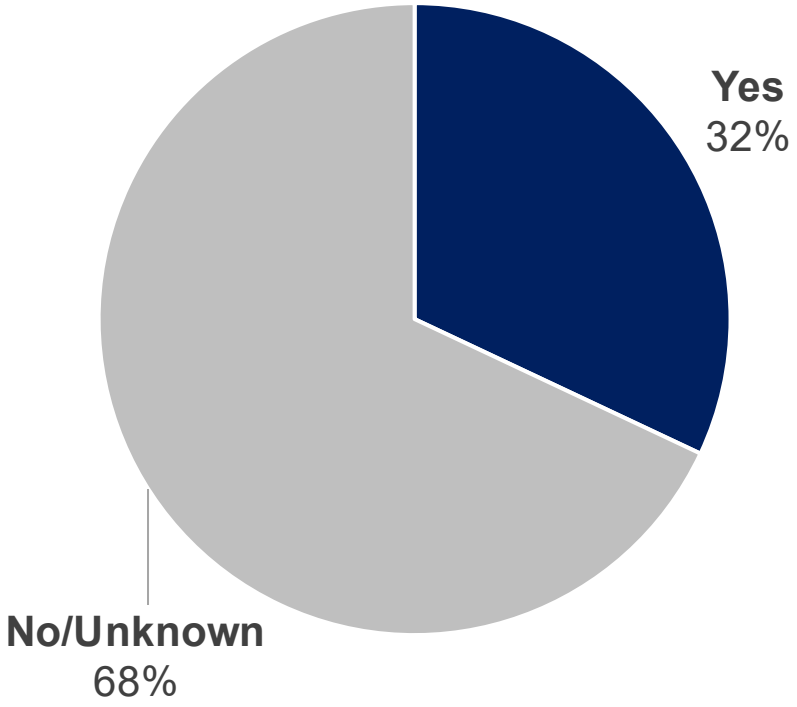
GV Incidents: Group/Gang Member Involvement

(Victims and/or suspects were group/gang-associated, regardless of incident motive)

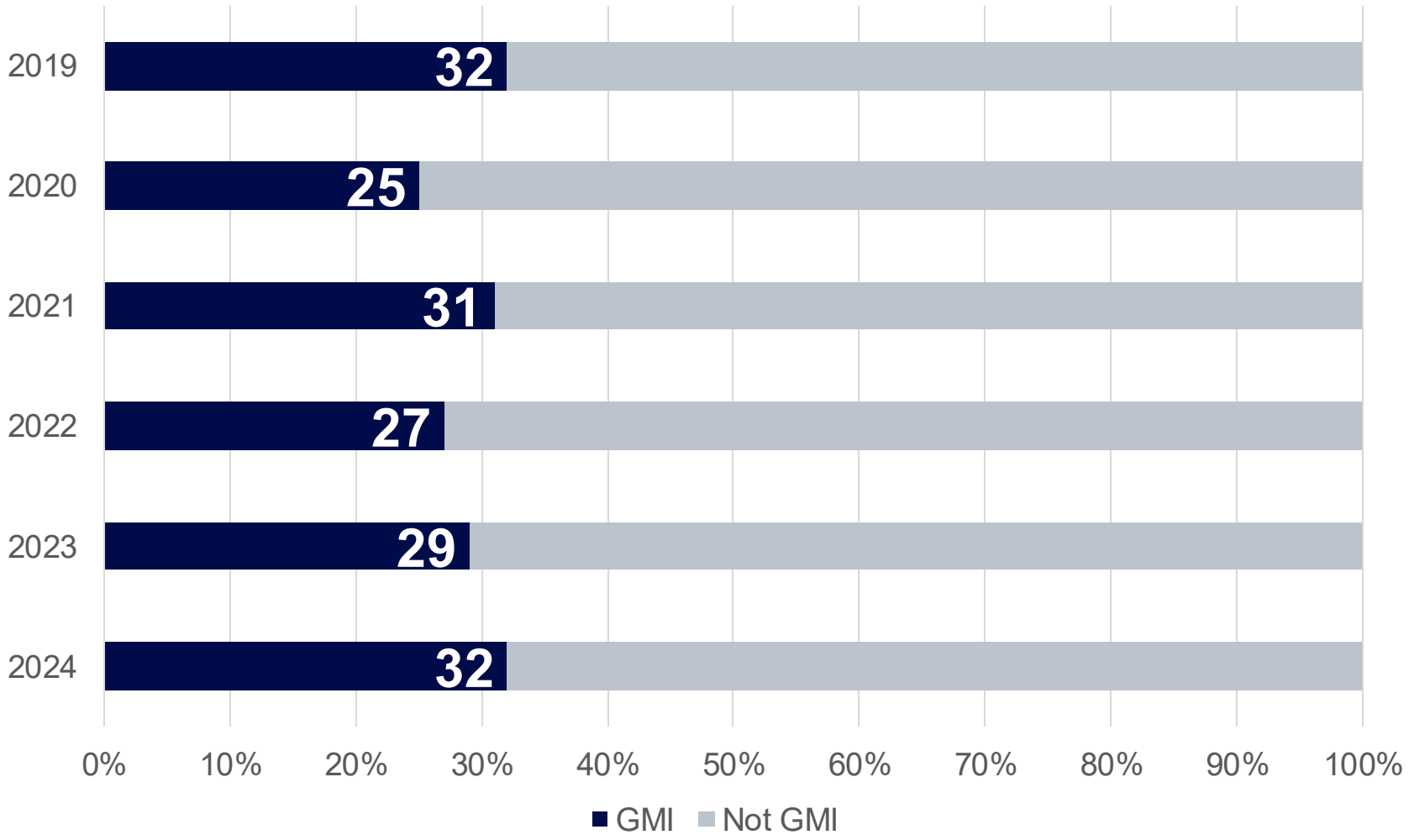
2019-2021
N=461



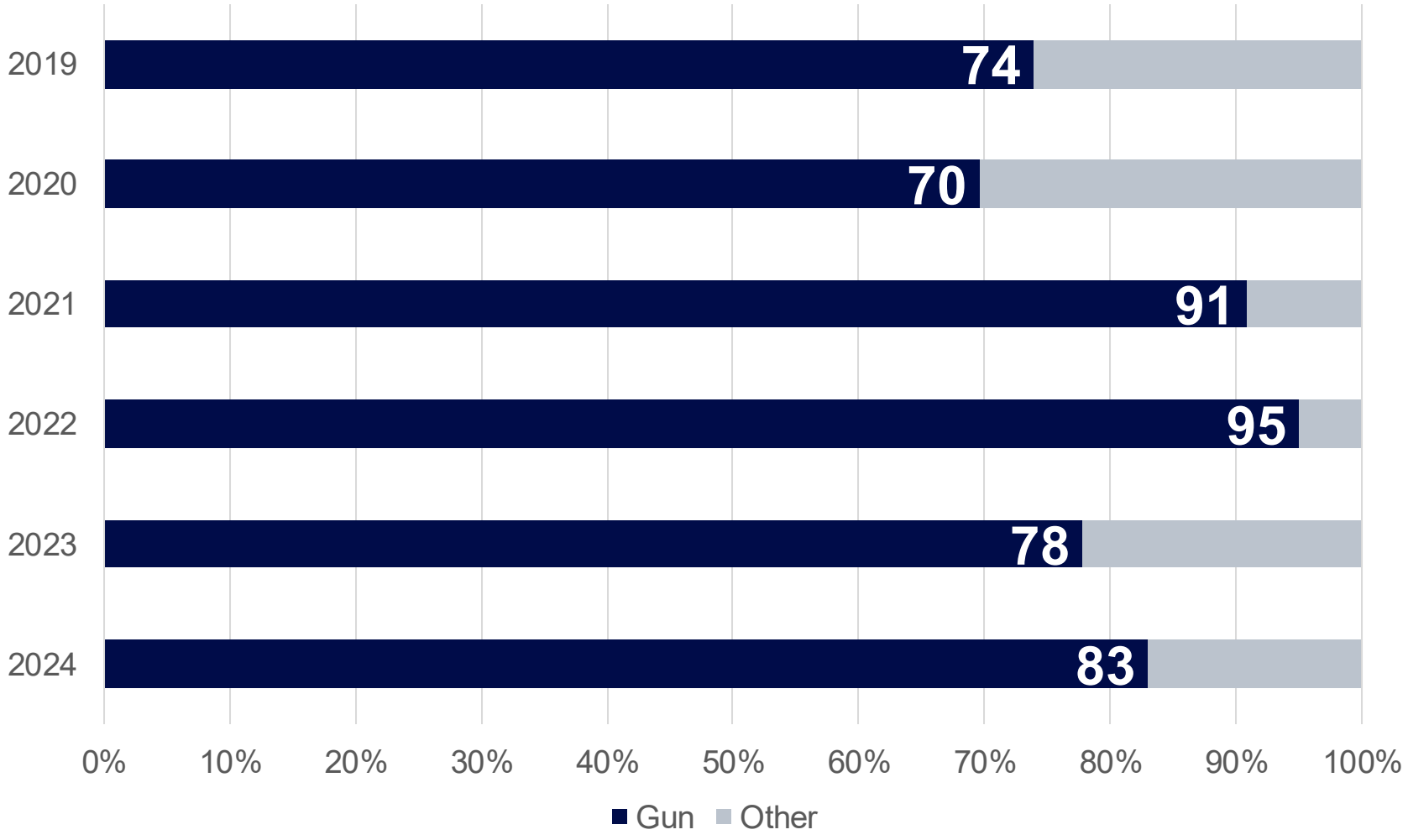
2022-2024
N=331



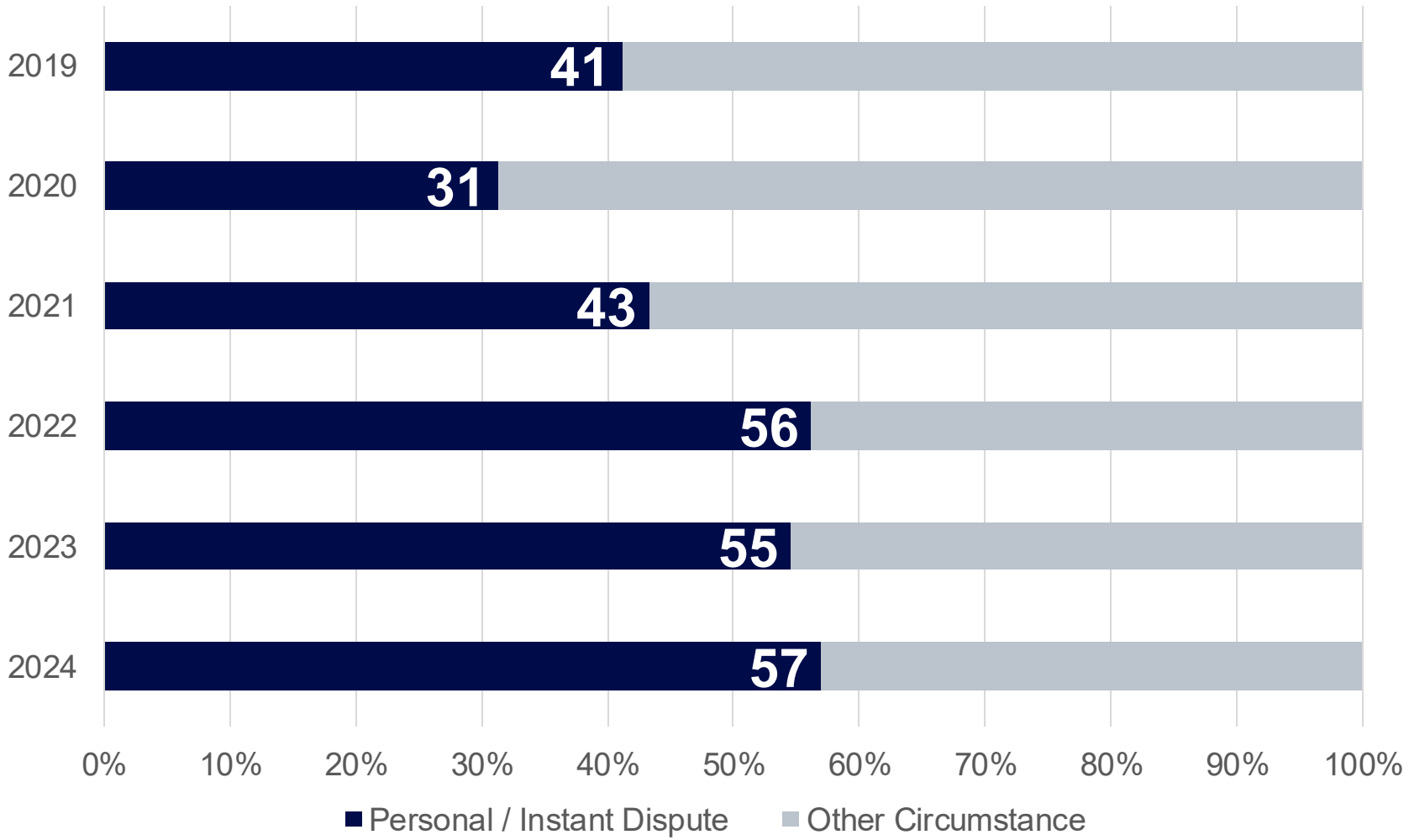
GV Incidents: % Group Member Involvement



All Homicides: % Cause of Death



Gun Homicides: % Personal / Instant Disputes



Summary

- In this section, two time periods were compared using previous and current problem analysis data. The first period included gun violence incidents from 2019-2021 and the second period included gun violence incidents from 2022-2024.
- There were no statistically significant changes in the sex of victims and suspects across these time periods, though suspects have gotten slightly older over time.
- Overall, the circumstances leading to gun violence were similar across time periods, but there were some notable changes:
  - There was a statistically significant increase in personal disputes in 2022-2024.
  - There was a statistically significant decrease in drug-related disputes in 2022-2024.
  - The proportion of robberies/carjackings significantly increased in 2024.

Summary

- About 91% and 95% of all homicides in 2021 and 2022, respectively, were gun homicides. This represented the highest proportion of gun homicides the city experienced over this six-year period.
- Though the proportion of gun homicides has decreased in 2023-2024, fatal shootings still account for a greater share of homicides when compared to 2019-2020.
- The proportion of gun homicides resulting from personal or sudden disputes has increased over time. While about 41% of gun homicides resulted from personal/instant disputes in 2019, about 57% of gun homicides resulted from personal/instant disputes in 2024.
- Overall, these patterns suggest that an increasing share of fatal violence evolves from adults aged 18-34 using firearms to address interpersonal disputes.

DISCUSSION OF FINDINGS

Summary Findings

Trends

- Hartford's average 10-year homicide rate is 22.3 per 100,000 population.
- Hartford's homicide rate increased about 87% from 2019 to 2022, but its rate decreased back to pre-pandemic levels by 2024.
- Fatal and nonfatal shootings in 2024 were about 55% lower than the city's highest level experienced in 2022.

Victim/Suspect Demographics

- The victims and suspects involved in gun violence were predominantly Black (66%) and Hispanic (33%) males (91%) with an average age of 31. Black individuals were overrepresented by a factor of 1.5 relative to Hartford's population overall.
- About 67% of Hartford's gun violence victims were Hartford residents.

Summary Findings

Victim/Suspect Criminal History

- About 69% of gun violence victims and suspects had prior criminal justice system involvement.
- Of those with previous arrests, most had extensive criminal justice system involvement. At least 54% had been previously incarcerated and at least 57% had been convicted of a felony.
- Victims and suspects had been arrested for about 8 different criminal offenses in Hartford prior to their involvement in the incident.

Summary Findings

Incidents and Circumstances

- Available information suggests that the primary drivers of violence are ongoing personal disputes and drug-related disputes.
- A notable proportion of fatal and nonfatal shootings were group/gang member involved:
  - About 48% of fatal shootings and 27% of nonfatal shootings involved group/gang members as victims, suspects, or both.
  - One group was associated with about 47% of all group member involved incidents from 2022-2024.
- Hot spots cover just over about 5.2 square miles, or about 30% of Hartford's land area, and about 76% of fatal and nonfatal shootings from 2022-2024 occurred within these identified hot spots.

Summary Findings

Time Period Comparisons

- There were no changes in the sex of victims and suspects, but overall, suspects have gotten slightly older over time.
- The circumstances leading to gun violence were largely similar over time, but there was a significant increase in personal disputes and a significant decrease in drug-related disputes in 2022-2024. Additionally, there was a significant increase in robberies/carjackings in 2024 alone.
- Group member involvement in gun violence has remained stable over time, with an average 29% of incidents each year involving group members as victims, suspects, or both.
- There was a 46% decrease in the number of gun violence incidents involving Group B members, and there was a 53% decrease in the number of gun violence incidents involving Group A members